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ARCHITECTURAL HISTORY SERIES

Art Nouveau

How a generation of architects, artists and craftspeople rebuilt the house around the curve — in Brussels, Paris, Barcelona, Vienna, Glasgow and far beyond, 1890–1914



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BOOK 1



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ARCHITECTURAL HISTORY SERIES · BOOK 1

Art Nouveau: The Complete History

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PERIOD

c. 1890–1910; flourishing 1895–1905

WHERE

Belgium and France first; then Spain, Austria, Germany, Scotland, Italy, Latvia, the Netherlands, Russia and the United States

LOCAL NAMES

Modernisme (Catalonia) · Jugendstil (Germany) · Sezession (Austria) · Stile Liberty (Italy) · Glasgow Style (Scotland)

SIGNATURE

The whiplash curve; structure as ornament; the total work of art, from facade to door handle

KEY FIGURES

Victor Horta · Hector Guimard · Antoni Gaudí · Lluís Domènech i Montaner · Otto Wagner · Joseph Maria Olbrich · Charles Rennie Mackintosh · Alphonse Mucha

LANDMARK BUILDINGS

Hôtel Tassel, Brussels · Castel Béranger, Paris · Casa Batlló, Barcelona · Secession Building, Vienna · Glasgow School of Art

ENDED BY

Cost, changing taste, the First World War — and its own children: Art Deco and modernism

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The Book at a Glance

Between about 1890 and 1910, architects across Europe and the Americas briefly agreed on something extraordinary: that a building should grow like a plant rather than stand like a monument. This book tells the whole story — where the whiplash curve came from, how it was built, who built it best, why it vanished, and why it still matters.

Period	c. 1890–1910; flourishing 1895–1905
Where	Belgium and France first; then Spain, Austria, Germany, Scotland, Italy, Latvia, the Netherlands, Russia and the United States
Local names	Modernisme (Catalonia) · Jugendstil (Germany) · Sezession (Austria) · Stile Liberty (Italy) · Glasgow Style (Scotland)
Signature	The whiplash curve; structure as ornament; the total work of art, from facade to door handle
Key figures	Victor Horta · Hector Guimard · Antoni Gaudí · Lluís Domènech i Montaner · Otto Wagner · Joseph Maria Olbrich · Charles Rennie Mackintosh · Alphonse Mucha
Landmark buildings	Hôtel Tassel, Brussels · Castel Béranger, Paris · Casa Batlló, Barcelona · Secession Building, Vienna · Glasgow School of Art
Ended by	Cost, changing taste, the First World War — and its own children: Art Deco and modernism

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Introduction

Art Nouveau was the first deliberately modern style in architecture: a movement that set out, self-consciously and in print, to create a design language with no historical precedent. Between roughly 1890 and 1910 — with a brilliant peak between 1895 and 1905 — it produced town houses in Brussels whose staircases flow like water, metro entrances in Paris cast as giant plants, apartment houses in Barcelona skinned in broken ceramic, an exhibition hall in Vienna crowned with a golden cabbage of laurel leaves, and a school of art in Glasgow whose windows anticipate the twentieth century. It had more names than any style before it: Art Nouveau in France and Belgium, Modernisme in Catalonia, Jugendstil in Germany, Sezessionstil in Austria, Stile Liberty in Italy, Glasgow Style in Scotland, Modern Style in England — one international movement wearing local dress.

This is the first book of the World Arch Journal Architectural History Series, and it is written to be used. It gives you the complete history first — origins, people, cities, materials, masterpieces — and then teaches you to read the style yourself, with the same five-sign identification method used across our Architectural History hub. Every building discussed is real, documented and, in most cases, still visitable; every photograph is licensed and credited; and the sources and literature behind every chapter are listed at the end, so you can go further with confidence.

A note on dates. No committee ever founded Art Nouveau, so its boundaries are argued over. We follow the broad scholarly convention: seeds in the early 1880s, first mature buildings in 1893, international triumph at the Paris Exposition of 1900, a hardening of the line after about 1905, and dissolution into war, cost and new geometries by 1914. Where a date matters and historians disagree, we say so.

A note on names. The movement's local labels — Jugendstil, Secession, Modernisme, Stile Liberty, Secese, Modern — are used in this book where they carry real meaning: a Viennese designer of 1900 who called himself a Secessionist was making a different claim from a Parisian who said Art Nouveau, and a Catalan who said Modernisme was making a political claim as well as an aesthetic one. Where the label adds nothing, we simply say Art Nouveau and mean the whole family. Architects' names are given in their common scholarly form; buildings keep the names by which their cities know them.

PART I

Origins and Arrival

What the new art was, where it came from, and how — by journal, shop and exhibition — it conquered a continent in a single decade.

ARCHITECTURAL HISTORY SERIES · BOOK 1

1

A Style That Refused to Copy: What Art Nouveau Is

The whiplash line

Not one style, but a family

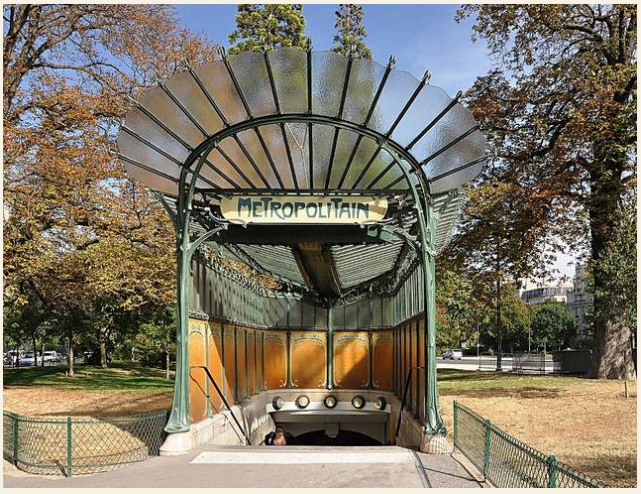


Photo: Moonik, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 3.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Metro_station_entrance_(%C3%A9dicule_Guimard)_Porte_Dauphine_Paris_16e_002.jpg

Stand in front of the Hôtel Tassel in Brussels, finished in 1894, and you are looking at a polite urban facade: stone, glass, a graceful oriel window. Nothing prepares you for the hall inside, where a cast-iron column rises from a mosaic floor, splits into tendrils, and pulls the staircase, the railing, the wall painting and the very light from the glass roof above into a single continuous gesture. That shock — a conventional house containing a completely new world — is the essence of Art Nouveau. It was not a new way of decorating old architecture. It was a claim that plan, structure, ornament and furniture are one act of design, and that this act should owe nothing to the styles of the past.

Every earlier nineteenth-century style had been a revival: neo-Gothic, neo-Renaissance, neo-Baroque, worn like costumes by banks, parliaments and villas. Art Nouveau's founders — most of them young, most of them trained in those very revivals — declared the costume party over. Victor Horta (1861–1947) in Brussels, Hector Guimard (1867–1942) in Paris and their contemporaries wanted what the journal L'Art Moderne called an art 'free of any imitation'. The name itself was a programme. When the Hamburg-born dealer Siegfried Bing reopened his Paris gallery in December 1895 as the Maison de l'Art Nouveau — the House of the New Art — he gave the movement the label that stuck in French and English. In Munich the journal Jugend (Youth) supplied Jugendstil; in Vienna, the artists who broke away in 1897 supplied Secession; in Barcelona, Modernisme simply meant modernity itself.

The whiplash line

The movement's signature is a line that behaves like a living stem: it swells, whips, hesitates and tapers, never repeating mechanically and rarely meeting another line at a right angle. Critics at the time named it with food and mockery — the 'noodle style', the 'eel line' — and admirers named it the whiplash curve (coup de fouet). You find it in Guimard's Métro railings, in the iron tendrils of Horta's stairs, in the hair of Alphonse Mucha's poster women, in the plan of a Gaudí apartment where walls themselves begin to undulate. The line was more than a fashion. It announced that ornament would no longer be applied from a pattern book of historical motifs but generated from the logic of growth — and it could be drawn by an architect on a facade, cast by a founder in iron, bent by a joiner in wood, or printed by a lithographer on a poster, uniting every scale of design in one handwriting.

Because the line was a method rather than a motif, Art Nouveau could absorb almost anything: Japanese woodblock composition, Celtic interlace, Rococo asymmetry, Gothic structure, the geometry of Viollet-le-Duc, the botany of Ernst Haeckel's radiating sea creatures. What made a work Art Nouveau was not a checklist of shapes but the fusion — of structure and decoration, of building and furnishing, of art and manufacture — pursued as a total work of art, a Gesamtkunstwerk for everyday life.

Not one style, but a family

Art Nouveau was never a single manner, and this book treats it as a family with strong local accents. Brussels produced the purest interiors, grown from iron and light. Paris turned the style toward cast iron, ceramics and the apartment house. Barcelona fused it with Catalan nationalism, Gothic memory and Mediterranean craft until it became something wilder — Gaudí is Art Nouveau's genius and its great exception, increasingly a category of one. Vienna subjected the curve to geometry until it squared into modernism. Glasgow stripped it to grid, rose and elongated figure. What unites them is chronological and temperamental: the same twenty years, the same refusal of revivalism, the same young designers reading the same journals and visiting the same exhibitions.

It is equally important to say what Art Nouveau is not. It is not Art Deco: Deco, its child of the 1920s, is symmetrical, machined, sunburst and zigzag where Nouveau is asymmetrical, organic and hand-finished. It is not the Arts and Crafts movement, its English elder cousin, which distrusted the machine that Nouveau designers delighted in. And it is not modernism proper, though it prepared modernism's ground — in Vienna and Glasgow you can watch it turning into modernism before your eyes. Keeping these borders clear is the first skill of reading buildings, and Chapter 15 returns to it with a field method you can use on any street.



Artwork: Alphonse Mucha, via Wikimedia Commons (public domain). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:JOB,_cigarette_paper_advertisement_by_Alfons_Mucha,_1898.jpg

ARCHITECTURAL HISTORY SERIES · BOOK 1

2

Roots: Industry, Nature and Revolt, 1850–1893

Japonisme and the printed image

The client: new money, new rooms



Artwork: Alphonse Mucha, via Wikimedia Commons (public domain). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Alphonse_Mucha_-_Poster_for_Victorien_Sardou%27s_Gismonda_starring_Sarah_Bernhardt.jpg

Art Nouveau was born from a contradiction. The nineteenth century had given architects miraculous new means — rolled iron, plate glass, the lift, electric light, the department store, the railway station — and then asked them to dress every one of those novelties as a Gothic chapel or a Renaissance palace. By the 1880s the contradiction had become a scandal discussed in every design journal in Europe. The engineer could build a train shed of unprecedented span; the architect could only apologise for it in stone. A generation educated in the academies began to ask why the most advanced civilisation in history had no architecture of its own.

Three liberations converged. The first was structural rationalism. Eugène Viollet-le-Duc, the great French restorer of Gothic buildings, had argued in his Entretiens sur l'architecture (1863–72) that Gothic was not a style but a logic — stone doing exactly what stone can do — and that iron, honestly used, demanded an equally honest new form. Horta and Guimard both read him closely; the Tassel stair, in which an iron column does the work and takes the decoration, is Viollet-le-Duc's argument built. The second liberation was the Arts and Crafts movement in Britain: William Morris and his circle had already taught Europe that design was a moral act, that the object and the room mattered as much as the monument, and that craft could be modern without being revivalist. The third was nature, newly seen: through the microscope, in the Japanese print, and in the Darwinian imagination of a world in which form follows growth.

Japonisme and the printed image

Japan's forced opening to trade in the 1850s, and the Japanese pavilions at the international exhibitions of 1862 (London) and 1867 (Paris), detonated a quiet bomb under European composition. Woodblock prints by Hokusai and Hiroshige offered asymmetry without disorder, flat colour without modelling, cropped compositions, and above all a line that described water, wind and plant growth with an economy European art had forgotten. Designers collected prints the way they collected ideas. The sinuous contour of the Art Nouveau poster, the flattened floral pattern, the diagonal composition of a Guimard facade — all carry this charge. Add the Symbolist painters, the Pre-Raphaelites' medievalising women, and the sinuous book illustration of Aubrey Beardsley, whose black line for Salome (1894) scandalised and inspired in equal measure, and the graphic DNA of the style is complete before a single building rises.

Print mattered in a second way: Art Nouveau was the first style propagated mainly by journals and exhibitions rather than by academies and state commissions. The Studio in London (from 1893), Pan in Berlin, L'Art Moderne in Brussels, Jugend in Munich, Ver Sacrum in Vienna and the catalogues of the great exhibitions carried photographs and drawings across borders within months. A young architect in Riga or Glasgow could study Horta's latest Brussels interior without leaving home. The style's famous simultaneity — mature works appearing within five years in a dozen cities — is a media effect as much as an artistic one.

The client: new money, new rooms

Styles need patrons, and Art Nouveau found a new kind. Its characteristic commissions were not palaces or cathedrals but the buildings of a prosperous, educated bourgeoisie: the town house (hôtel) in Brussels, the apartment block in Paris, the department store, the café, the studio-house, the exhibition pavilion, the metro entrance. Its Brussels patrons were engineers, scientists and industrialists — Émile Tassel was a professor and associate of the Solvay chemical fortune; Armand Solvay, who commissioned the Hôtel Solvay, inherited one of Europe's great industrial companies. In Barcelona, the textile magnate Eusebi Güell bankrolled Gaudí for forty years. These clients wanted modernity they could live in: houses planned around light, hygiene, servants' circulation and display, built by the same industries that had made their fortunes. Art Nouveau is, among other things, the moment industrial money stopped apologising and started designing.

It also arrived exactly when the techniques to build it became cheap. Cast iron could be founded from a carved wooden pattern in unlimited vegetal complexity at no greater cost than a classical capital; ceramic tiles could be printed, glazed and fired by the thousand; large sheets of glass, bent wood, reinforced concrete in its infancy, and the electric bulb all entered the builder's catalogue in the same two decades. The style's tragedy is already visible here: its finest effects still depended on hand-finishing — on mosaicists, glass-painters, carvers and smiths — and hand labour was about to become the most expensive thing in Europe. Chapter 10 returns to the material basis of the style in detail.

ARCHITECTURAL HISTORY SERIES · BOOK 1

3
Exhibitions: How the Style Conquered the World in a Decade

1900, Turin 1902, Darmstadt 1901: the summit circuit

The journals: the style in print



Artwork: Gustav Klimt, via Wikimedia Commons (public domain). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Klimt_-_Beethovenfries_-_Mittelwand.jpg

No previous style had a distribution network; Art Nouveau had three — the journal, the shop and the exhibition — and the exhibition was the loudest. The nineteenth century had perfected the international exhibition as a machine for manufacturing taste: nations and industries displayed, juries awarded, newspapers illustrated, and millions walked through. When the new art learned to operate the machine, it achieved in ten years a geographic spread that Gothic had needed two centuries to manage. This chapter follows that conquest, because the exhibition circuit explains both the style's simultaneity and its burnout.

The circuit opened in Brussels, where the salons of Les XX and La Libre Esthétique had already, in the 1880s and 90s, hung the new painting beside the new furniture in townhouses converted to galleries. Siegfried Bing industrialised the lesson: his Maison de l'Art Nouveau (1895) was a permanent exhibition with a till, its rooms furnished as total interiors by Van de Velde, Gaillard and others, so that a visitor did not admire objects but walked through a thesis. Bing then took the thesis on tour, supplying the Grafton Gallery exhibition in London (1899) and the Paris pavilion of 1900, and shipping Tiffany glass, Danish porcelain and Japanese crafts in both directions across the Atlantic. The style's internationalism was not a spirit in the air; it was, in part, one dealer's stock list.

1900, Turin 1902, Darmstadt 1901: the summit circuit

The Paris Exposition Universelle of 1900 was the style's coronation and its first autopsy, held simultaneously. Fifty million visitors saw the Porte Monumentale — René Binet's great gate derived from Haeckel's radiolarians, biology as portal — passed under Guimard's Métro entrances, and crowded Bing's pavilion of furnished rooms. Yet the same fair displayed the style already hardening into formula in the commercial pavilions, and its juries distributed medals with a generosity that devalued the currency. Darmstadt answered in 1901 with the opposite format: instead of pavilions, a whole colony — 'A Document of German Art' exhibited finished, furnished artists' houses, Olbrich's Ernst Ludwig House with its great studio front at their centre. Turin followed in 1902 with the First International Exhibition of Modern Decorative Art, where the rules excluded anything retrospective: for one summer, the new style was not a section of the fair but the fair itself, and Raimondo D'Aronco's pavilions gave Italy its canonical image of the Stile Liberty.

The Vienna Secession ran the most rigorous version of the model: twenty-three exhibitions between 1898 and 1905 in Olbrich's little building, importing the Glasgow Four (1900), the Ashbee guild, Van de Velde and the French, and exporting the Beethoven Exhibition of 1902 as the movement's sacred rite. Glasgow's showing in Vienna in 1900 deserves its emphasis: the Mackintoshes' white room, with the Macdonalds' gesso panels, electrified the Secessionists, and Viennese critics wrote of the Scottish room as the exhibition's revelation. Influence in this period did not flow from centre to province; it circulated, at the speed of the railway timetable, among a dozen capitals that took turns teaching one another. When the circuit broke in 1914, the style discovered how much of its life the circuit had been.



Photo: C.Stadler/Bwag, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 4.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Wien_-_Secessionsgeb%C3%A4ude.JPG

The journals: the style in print

Underpinning the exhibitions ran the printed network that Chapter 2 introduced. The Studio (London, from 1893) made the new design a middle-class subscription; Pan (Berlin, 1895–1900) printed it like scripture on handmade paper; Dekorative Kunst and Deutsche Kunst und Dekoration fought its corner in Germany; L'Art Moderne and Van Nu en Straks carried Brussels; Ver Sacrum gave the Secession a monthly flag; and in Barcelona, the satirical and cultural press made Modernisme a matter of cartoons and civic pride. The journals did three kinds of work at once: they published the drawings (often the only record of interiors since destroyed), they standardised the vocabulary — a Riga architect could order his ornament from the same plates as a Glasgow one — and they created the critical arena in which the style argued with itself. Art Nouveau is unimaginable without them: it was the first architectural movement whose primary medium, for most of its audience, was reproduction. That is also why it could die so quickly in the original and live so long in the copy — the paper archive outlasted the buildings' fashion by half a century, and powered the revival of Chapter 17.

PART II

The Capitals of the New Art

Brussels invents it; Paris publicises it; Barcelona, Vienna and Glasgow translate it; the wider map, from Riga to Budapest, proves it a European language.

ARCHITECTURAL HISTORY SERIES · BOOK 1

4
Brussels: The Town House Reimagined

Hôtel Tassel (1893–94): the first interior

Solvay, Van Eetvelde and Horta's own house

Why Brussels led

Hankar, and the circle around Horta

The money, and its shadow

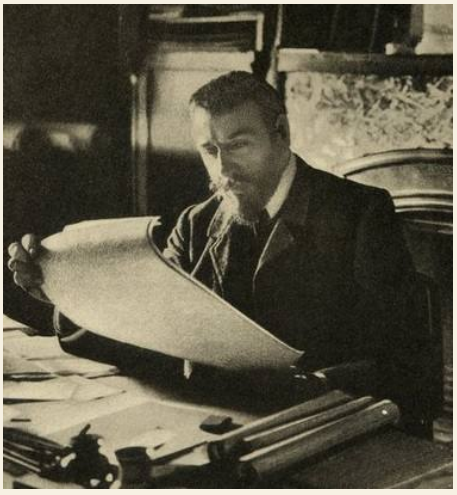


Photo: Gustave Deltour, via Wikimedia Commons (public domain). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Victor_Horta_(cropped).jpg

If Art Nouveau has a birthplace, it is a narrow street in Brussels, and the midwife was a peculiarly Belgian combination: a small, rich, industrial country; a capital being rebuilt with Parisian ambition; a class of engineer-industrialists eager for modern houses; and two young architects of genius working a few streets apart. In 1893 Paul Hankar (1859–1901) built his own house at 71 rue Defacqz, its facade a manifesto of sgraffito panels, exposed iron and Japanese-flavoured geometry. The same year Victor Horta began the house that would define the style. Hankar died young and Horta inherited the century; but Brussels never forgot that the new architecture began as a duel of neighbours.

Horta had trained at the Brussels Academy and worked in Paris before returning to a city whose building plots were famously narrow and deep — typically six to eight metres of street frontage with a long body behind. The traditional Brussels hôtel buried its middle rooms in darkness. Horta's revolution began as a solution to this humble problem: he opened the plan around a top-lit stairwell, turned the stair into the house's luminous spine, and let structure — slender iron columns, exposed beams — carry both the loads and the decoration. Light, air and movement, not applied ornament, were the luxury he sold.

Hôtel Tassel (1893–94): the first interior

The Hôtel Tassel, at 6 rue Paul-Émile Janson, was commissioned by Émile Tassel, a university professor and photographer. From the street it is an accomplished stone facade with a projecting oriel carried on iron — modern, but not yet shocking. Inside, everything changes. The entrance hall's mosaic floor curls in ochre tendrils; iron columns, thin as stems, rise and branch to carry the floor above; the stair sweeps upward in a single flowing line, its railing drawn in space like a signature, while painted tendrils on the wall continue the ironwork's drawing onto the flat surface. A glass roof pours light down the stairwell into the centre of the plan. Contemporaries recognised the event: the Tassel house was published across Europe, and 'the Horta style' — contemporaries also called it the 'whiplash style' — became a exportable idea. UNESCO inscribed the house in 2000 as one of the four Major Town Houses of Victor Horta, calling them 'among the most remarkable pioneering works of architecture of the end of the 19th century'.

What exactly was new? Not the plan alone, nor the iron, nor the curve, but their indivisibility. In a Beaux-Arts interior, structure is concealed and decoration is added by other hands; at the Tassel, the architect's single drawn line generates column, railing, mosaic, lamp and door handle. Horta designed the furniture, the carpets, the light fittings — the house as a total environment, tuned to one family's rituals. Every great Art Nouveau interior since is a variation on this Brussels invention.



Photo: Henry Townsend, via Wikimedia Commons (public domain). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Tassel_House_stairway.JPG

Solvay, Van Eetvelde and Horta's own house

Success brought richer stages. The Hôtel Solvay (1894–98) on the avenue Louise, built for Armand Solvay, is the sumptuous elder sibling: a symphonic stair under a glazed canopy, marble, onyx, tropical woods, a vast landscape by the pointillist Théo van Rysselberghe, and craftsmanship of a level that makes the house a standing rebuke to the idea that Art Nouveau was cheap or flimsy — it was neither. The Hôtel Van Eetvelde (1895–1901), for the administrator of the Congo Free State, pushed the type further with an octagonal winter garden under a stained-glass dome. Then, in 1898–1901, Horta built for himself at 23–25 rue Américaine in Saint-Gilles: house and studio joined, the stair again top-lit and flower-like, the facade in stone with an iron balcony drawn as casually as handwriting. That house is now the Horta Museum, and it remains the most complete surviving demonstration of the Brussels idea: a building in which there is no line between architecture and decoration because one mind drew both.

The same years produced the style's great public and commercial works in Brussels. For the Belgian Workers' Party, Horta built the Maison du Peuple (1896–99), a people's house of auditorium, offices and café wrapped in a curving iron-and-glass facade that followed the awkward site like a drawn line — proof the style could serve politics and crowds, not only professors. Its demolition in 1965, despite international protest, became a founding trauma of the conservation movement. Paul Saintenoy's Old England department store (1898–99) raised a black iron-and-glass palace on the Mont des Arts, its facade a grid of slender metal and huge windows that looks forward to the curtain wall. And just outside the capital's centre, in Uccle, the painter-designer Henry van de Velde — a convert from painting who preached the unity of the arts — built his own Villa Bloemenwerf (1895–96), plainer and more domestic, and carried the Brussels gospel to Germany, where he would direct the Weimar school whose successor was the Bauhaus.

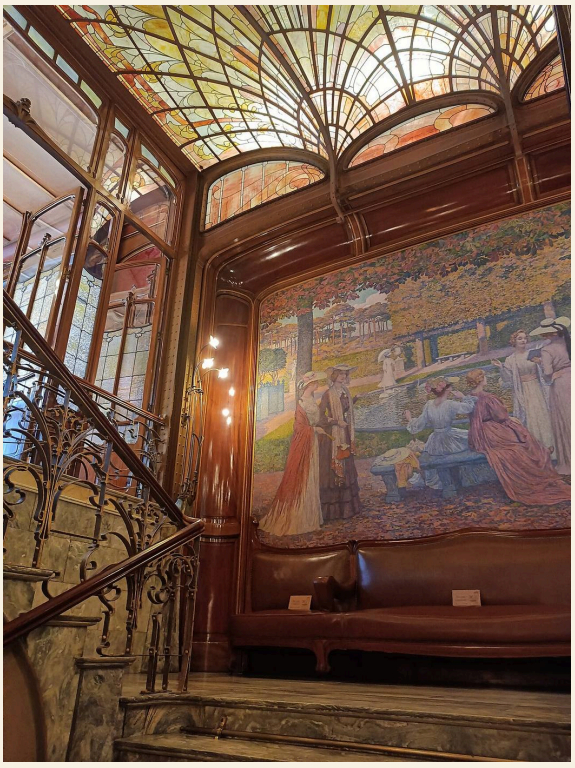


Photo: Brigade Piron, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY 3.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:H%C3%B4tel_Solvay_-_Main_Stairs.jpg

Why Brussels led

Brussels' lead was not an accident of taste. Belgium was the continent's first industrial nation, dense with foundries, glassworks and skilled metal trades; its capital offered a building type — the narrow urban hôtel — perfectly sized for total design; its patrons were technical men who respected engineers; and its art world, organised around the exhibiting society Les XX and its successor La Libre Esthétique, was the most internationally connected in Europe, showing Van Gogh, Seurat and the Nabis to the same public that commissioned houses. When the century turned, the Brussels synthesis — plan opened to light, iron as drawing, ornament as growth — was ready to be translated into every European language. The translations, and the geniuses who made them, fill the next four chapters.



Photo: Victor Horta, via Wikimedia Commons (CC0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Maison_Horta_(23-25,_rue_Am%C3%A9ricaine,_1060,_Brussels).jpg

Hankar, and the circle around Horta

Brussels was a school, not a solo act. Paul Hankar, whose own house of 1893 shares the birth-year honours with the Tassel, developed a cooler, more geometric variant — sgraffito friezes, exposed iron, Japanese woodwork logic — and his studio trained a generation before his early death in 1901. Gustave Serrurier-Bovy, a Liège furniture-maker who had seen Morris's England, became the style's Belgian retailer, opening shops and selling complete interiors by catalogue: Art Nouveau as a purchasable system. The painter Fernand Khnopff and the exhibiting societies Les XX (1883–93) and La Libre Esthétique (from 1894) made Brussels the turntable on which French, British and Scandinavian novelties were exchanged; it was at their salons that a young designer could measure himself against Seurat, Van Gogh, Beardsley and Crane in a single afternoon.

Horta himself outlived his style by four decades, and the long coda matters. He designed the vast Palais des Beaux-Arts (1919–28), hid the whiplash in a personal classicism, spent the war years in Britain and America lecturing, and was made a baron in 1932 — the rebel absorbed, as rebels are, into the establishment he had scandalised. His memoirs, published after his death in 1947, still burn with the conviction of 1893. Brussels after 1900 exported the style and imported doubts; but every European capital that took up the new art took it up, in the first instance, from the evidence of two Brussels streets.

The money, and its shadow

A complete history must also follow the money, and in Brussels the trail has a shadow. Belgium's industrial wealth was real, but the Belgian state's other fortune — Leopold II's Congo Free State, whose rubber revenues in the 1890s and 1900s were extracted by a regime whose atrocities became an international scandal — washed through the capital's building boom. The Hôtel van Eetvelde (1895–98), one of Horta's most dazzling houses, was commissioned by Edmond van Eetvelde, the senior administrator of the Congo Free State; Ernest Solvay's chemical fortune was cleaner, built on the ammonia-soda process, but the era's Brussels splendour and the Congo's suffering are contemporaries, and some of the same francs paid for both. Historians of the style now write this into the record rather than around it, and the buildings are not diminished by the knowledge: the Tassel stair is as beautiful, and the ledger beneath it as necessary to read, as ever. Architecture's patrons have rarely been innocent; a grown-up history keeps both facts in focus at once.

ARCHITECTURAL HISTORY SERIES · BOOK 1

5

Paris: Guimard, the Métro and the Triumph of 1900

The Métro entrances: the style goes underground, and public

Nancy and the French provinces

The department store, and the critics

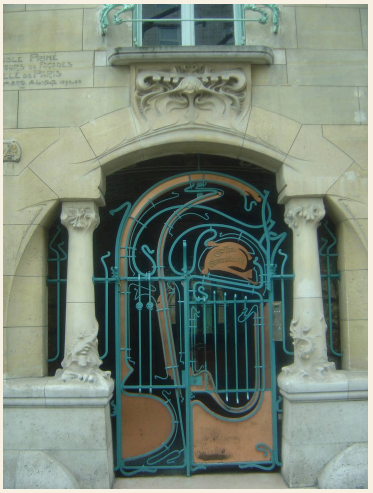


Photo: DIMSFIKAS, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 3.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Art_Nouveau_entrance_to_Castel_Beranger,_Paris_-_2011.jpg

Paris received the new style with its usual combination of genius and suspicion. The capital of historicism — the city of the École des Beaux-Arts, which trained the world's architects to compose in the classical orders — was also the capital of fashion, print and luxury manufacture, and it converted Art Nouveau into something more urban, more reproducible and more commercial than the Brussels original. Its presiding architect was Hector Guimard, a Lyon-born designer of ferocious energy and self-belief, who visited Brussels in 1895, met Horta, saw the Hôtel Tassel — and went home to transform what he had learned into a personal system he called the Style Guimard.

Guimard's opportunity was the Castel Béranger (1895–98), a thirty-six-apartment block at 14 rue La Fontaine in the 16th arrondissement, commissioned by Madame Fournier. Where Horta's houses are single-family essays, the Castel is an urban apartment house, and Guimard treats its stone, brick, iron and ceramic skin as a single growing organism: windows of a dozen shapes, balconies like seed pods, and an entrance gate whose interlacing iron tendrils became the most reproduced doorway in Europe. In 1898 the building won the City of Paris's first facade competition, and its architect became famous overnight. He married the moment to a business model: the Castel's ironwork, and later his Métro entrances, were cast from standardised patterns at the Saint-Dizier foundries — Art Nouveau as catalogue industry, the total work of art reproduced by the dozen.

The Métro entrances: the style goes underground, and public

In 1898–1900 the Compagnie du chemin de fer métropolitain needed entrances for Paris's first underground line, and a competition for their design collapsed in embarrassment — the municipal favourite's masonry kiosks were judged too funereal. Guimard, though not the winner, got the commission through the company's president, and he delivered the most successful pieces of public design of the age: entrances in green-painted cast iron, their stalks rising to carry amber glass canopies like lily pads, the word 'Métropolitain' written in a lettering of pure tendril that Guimard drew himself. Parisians mocked them as 'noodle style' and adopted them in the same breath. About 141 entrances of the first campaign were built; most were later simplified or replaced, and today only a handful of the elaborate types survive — including the two roofed pavilions at Porte Dauphine and Abbesses — protected as historic monuments and loved as the city's logo in iron. Their historical importance is larger than their charm: for the first time, the avant-garde style was not a rich man's interior but the everyday furniture of a whole metropolis, cast in series, identical in every arrondissement.

The Paris Exposition Universelle of 1900 sealed the triumph and began the dilution. Bing's pavilion presented furnished Art Nouveau rooms to the world; Guimard's entrances dotted the fair's city; and from Tokyo to Buenos Aires, buyers ordered the style by the catalogue. Paris also gave the movement its most delirious apartment house, Jules Lavirotte's building at 29 avenue Rapp (1901), where the facade is a stone jungle of lizards, leaves and a famously sensuous doorway, faced with Alexandre Bigot's glazed stoneware — ceramics doing the work of sculpture. Its excess is instructive: by 1901 the style in Paris was already performing for an audience that had learned to expect astonishment, and astonishment is a wasting asset.

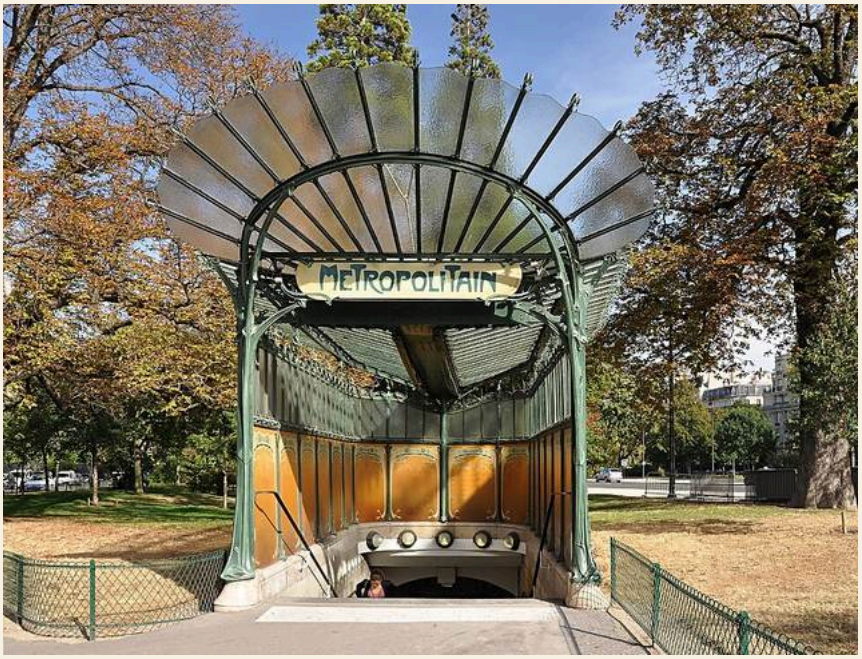


Photo: Moonik, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 3.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Metro_station_entrance_(%C3%A9dicule_Guimard)_Porte_Dauphine_Paris_16e_002.jpg

Nancy and the French provinces

Paris was the amplifier, but provincial France produced a second school of real distinction. In Nancy, in Lorraine, the glassmaker Émile Gallé and the furniture-maker Louis Majorelle led the École de Nancy (formalised 1901), applying the style to glass, marquetry and furniture of museum quality, with ornament drawn from Lorraine's flora with almost scientific fidelity. Majorelle's own Villa Majorelle (1901–02), designed with the Paris architect Henri Sauvage, carried the manner into architecture. Nancy matters to the historian because it shows the style's craft wing at full stretch — and its limits: these were luxury manufactures for connoisseurs, priced for the few, at the very moment when design reformers were beginning to ask what beauty owed the many.

Guimard built on — the Castel Henriette at Sèvres (1899, demolished 1969), the Humbert de Romans concert hall with its daring concrete-and-iron dome (1901, demolished), and, after a cooling of fashion, the serene Hôtel Guimard (1909–12) for himself and his American wife. His later work calms the line into something close to the coming Deco. He died in New York in 1942, nearly forgotten in the city he had signed in iron — a measure of how completely the wheel turned within one lifetime.



Photo: Binche, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 3.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Immeuble_Lavirotte_-_Paris_-_France_-_Facade.jpg

The department store, and the critics

Paris also gave the style its largest public interiors: the grands magasins, the department stores that were the cathedrals of the new consumer city. At La Samaritaine, Frantz Jourdain — painter, critic and the style's most tireless French publicist — built from 1905 a store of exposed steel and glass wrapped in enamelled lava-stone panels and a frescoed frieze by his son Francis: shopping under a painted sky, the total work of art at the scale of a city block. The stores matter because they took the style out of the private hôtel and made it the environment of the crowd — clerks and customers alike moved through Art Nouveau rooms daily, years before most Europeans had seen an Art Nouveau house.

Success bred the backlash in real time. The press christened the manner the style nouille — the noodle style — and the style métro when Guimard's entrances multiplied; academicians denounced its 'spaghetti' ironwork and its contempt for the orders; and the satire bit because it was aimed at something genuinely ubiquitous. A complete history should keep the mockery in the record, because it explains the speed of the fall (Chapter 16): a style that has become a joke about noodles by 1902 has perhaps five years of serious life left, and Paris spent them brilliantly.

ARCHITECTURAL HISTORY SERIES · BOOK 1

6

Barcelona: Modernisme and the Genius of Gaudí

Gaudí before Batlló: Güell and the long apprenticeship

Casa Batlló (1904–06) and Casa Milà (1906–12)

Park Güell and the unfinished cathedral

Puig i Cadafalch, Jujol and the workshop

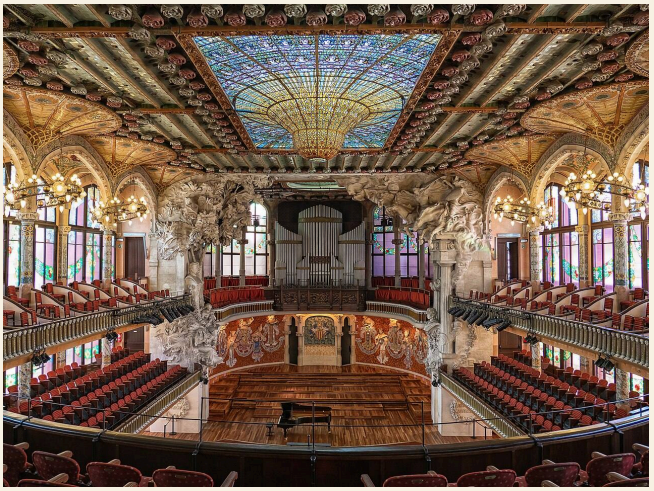


Photo: Tudoi61, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 4.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Palau_de_la_M%C3%BAsica_Catalana-Palace_of_Catalan_Music_(Image_2).jpg

In Barcelona the new style found its most fertile ground and its greatest artist — and became something more than a style. Catalan Modernisme was the cultural wing of the Renaixença, the Catalan national revival: a wealthy industrial region asserting its language, its Gothic past and its Mediterranean identity against Madrid's centralism. Barcelona's grid expansion, the Eixample, laid out by Ildefons Cerdà from 1859, offered a chessboard of chamfered blocks on which a generation of architects — Antoni Gaudí (1852–1926), Lluís Domènech i Montaner (1850–1923), Josep Puig i Cadafalch (1867–1956) — competed in brick, ceramic, iron and stained glass for the textile fortunes of the Catalan bourgeoisie. The Passeig de Gràcia became their battlefield: the famous 'block of discord', the Mansana de la Discòrdia, still lines up Puig's Casa Amatller (1898–1900), Domènech's Casa Lleó Morera (1902–06) and Gaudí's Casa Batlló (1904–06) shoulder to shoulder, three dialects of one language arguing in stone.

Domènech, professor and politician as well as architect, built the style's two great civic monuments. The Palau de la Música Catalana (1905–08), a concert hall for the Orfeó Català choir, is a greenhouse of music: a steel-framed box wrapped in stained glass, its central skylight an inverted dome of coloured sun, its stage framed by mosaic muses. The Hospital de Sant Pau (begun 1901, built over three decades), a garden-city of brick pavilions linked by underground tunnels, made Modernisme serve public health with the same exuberance. UNESCO inscribed both in 1997. If Gaudí is the movement's poet, Domènech is its statesman — proof that the style could carry a whole civic culture.

Gaudí before Batlló: Güell and the long apprenticeship

Gaudí, the son of a Reus coppersmith, trained in Barcelona and spent twenty years as a brilliant eclectic — Moorish brick at the Casa Vicens (1883–85), Gothic iron at the Palau Güell — before the works of his maturity detonated every category. His patron was Eusebi Güell, the richest industrialist in Catalonia, and their forty-year collaboration is one of the great patronages in architectural history. The Palau Güell (1886–90), Güell's mansion off the Rambla, already contains the future: parabolic arches carrying the entrance, a central hall rising through the house to a perforated dome that rains needles of light, and a roof terrace where twenty chimneys are treated as a sculpture garden of broken tile. The technique that made the later work possible — trencadís, mosaic made of shattered ceramic waste — turns economy into shimmer. Gaudí's structural imagination was equally radical: at the Colònia Güell crypt (1908–14) he designed by hanging chains and weights, letting gravity draw the vaults, an analogue computer in string.



Photo: Adam Jones, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 2.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Facade_of_Gaudi%27s_Casa_Guell_-_Barcelona_-_Spain_(14327581624).jpg

Casa Batlló (1904–06) and Casa Milà (1906–12)

The Casa Batlló is not a new building but a total transformation: Gaudí took a conventional 1875 apartment house on the Passeig de Gràcia and re-skinned, re-planned and re-imagined it for the textile manufacturer Josep Batlló. The facade undulates in stone the colour of waterlilies, freckled with blue-green trencadís; balconies like masks or skulls hang from it; the roof ridge swells into the scaly back of a dragon, pierced by a cross-bearing turret — Catalans read the whole as Saint George and the dragon, their national legend, and they are not wrong to. Inside, the noble floor is an underwater room: doors with no straight edges, a fireplace nook like a mushroom cave, windows that regulate light and air with wooden veins. Nothing in the house is merely decorated; every curve is working — carrying light down the central well, whose tiles grade from deep blue at the top to white at the bottom to equalise the daylight, or moving air through the plan. It is the most complete Art Nouveau interior ensemble in Spain, and UNESCO extended its protection in 2005.

Casa Milà (1906–12), the last great work, is known to Barcelona as La Pedrera, the stone quarry — a nickname of awe and complaint. Its facade is a self-supporting cliff of undulating stone: the walls carry themselves, so the plan inside is free, organised around two courtyards, and the apartments can be partitioned at will. On the roof, chimneys and ventilation towers stand like masked sentinels, designed with the sculptor Josep Maria Jujol. Below ground lies one of the earliest underground garages. Contemporaries mocked La Pedrera; modern architects pilgrimaged to it. Between the two houses, Gaudí had travelled from ornament to organism: the building as a living system, which is why his work outgrew the movement that midwifed it.

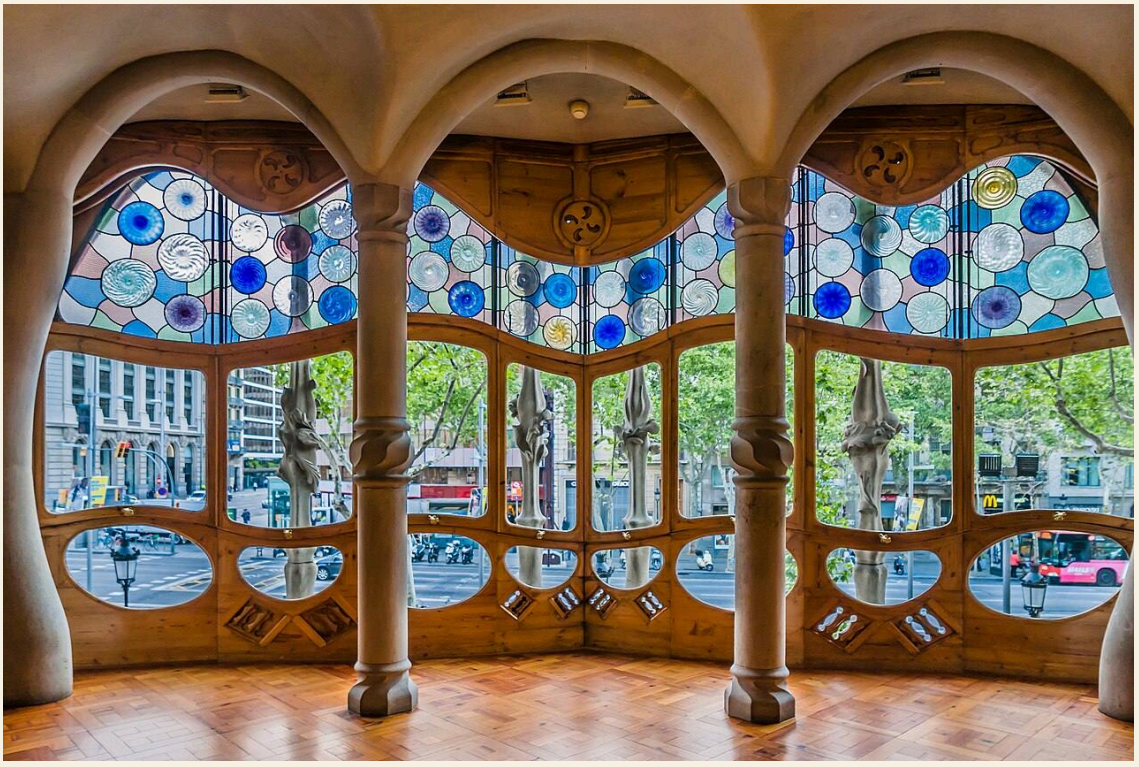


Photo: Sara Terrones, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 4.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:CasaBatll%C3%B3_NobleFloor_saloon_stainedglass.jpg

Park Güell and the unfinished cathedral

Park Güell (1900–14) began as Güell's utopia — a garden city of sixty houses above Barcelona — and failed as business while succeeding as art. Only two houses were built, but Gaudí's public works for the park became the city's emblem: the entrance stair with its mosaic salamander, El Drac; the Hypostyle Hall of eighty-six leaning columns meant as a market; and above it the great terrace whose undulating bench, skinned in trencadís by Jujol, is perhaps the most joyful seat in architecture. And beyond the park looms the work that consumed Gaudí's last decades and still rises today: the Sagrada Família, begun by another architect in 1882 and directed by Gaudí from 1883 until his death under a tram in 1926. Its forest of branching columns and its ruled-surface geometry belong to this book because they are Modernisme's logic pursued to the end — nature not as ornament but as structure. Gaudí died a pauper-saint of his own cathedral; Barcelona buried him like a king. The movement he transcended had already ended, but in Catalonia it had achieved what it achieved nowhere else: it had become the architecture of a nation remembering itself forward.



Photo: Joe Mabel, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 4.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Park_G%C3%BCell_-_main_steps_and_Drac_05.jpg

Puig i Cadafalch, Jujol and the workshop

The third man of the Passeig de Gràcia deserves his paragraph. Josep Puig i Cadafalch built the Casa Amatller (1898–1900) for the chocolate manufacturer Antoni Amatller as a Flemish-Gothic town palace translated into Catalan: stepped gable, sgraffito, a photographic studio-crown for the owner's hobby, and interiors by the best craft workshops in the city. Puig — historian of Romanesque architecture, later president of the Mancomunitat de Catalunya — shows Modernisme's scholarly pole, as Domènech's Castell dels Tres Dragons (1887–88), built for the 1888 exhibition, shows its brick-and-iron origin before the style had a name. A complete account of Barcelona must also name the collaborator without whom the mature Gaudí is unthinkable: Josep Maria Jujol (1879–1949), the young architect-artist who from 1906 supplied the trencadís of Park Güell's bench, the painted ceilings and ironwork of Casa Milà, and a calligraphic freedom that loosened even Gaudí's hand. Modern scholarship increasingly credits the late Gaudí works as collaborations, and the buildings support it: the colour sings in two voices.

Before the masters, the seed: Domènech's Castell dels Tres Dragons, built as the café-restaurant of the 1888 Universal Exposition, raised exposed brick and iron into a manifesto a decade before the style had a Catalan name — the workshop-school attached to it trained the craftsmen who would later glaze the Palau de la Música. And in the Casa Amatller next door to Batlló, Puig i Cadafalch ran the opposite experiment to Gaudí's: where Gaudí dissolved history into organism, Puig quoted it — Flemish gable, Gothic tracery, Catalan sgraffito — with such precision that the house reads as a library of the national past, alphabetised. That the same street could sustain both methods at the highest level is the measure of Barcelona's moment.

Beneath the named masters stood the workshops — the Rigalt glass studios, the Masriera foundries, the tile works of Escofet, the mosaicists and stonecarvers of a city that still trained them. Modernisme's density on the street, hundreds of tiled vestibules and carved doorways deep, is their collective signature. When the style is called a national movement, this is the concrete meaning: an entire building culture, from cathedral to door knocker, briefly designing in one language.

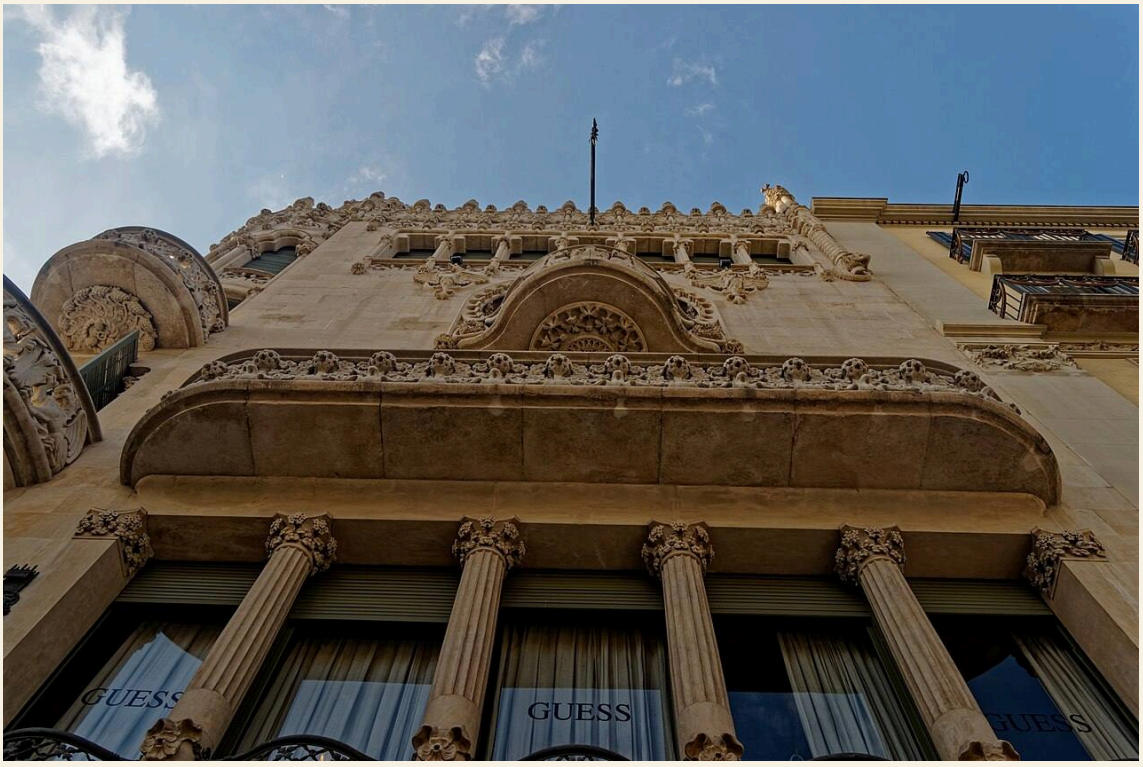


Photo: TxllxT TxllxT, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 4.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Barcelona_-_Passeig_de_Gr%C3%A0cia_-_Casa_Lle%C3%B3-Morera_1902_Llu%C3%ADs_Dom%C3%A8nech_i_Montaner.jpg

ARCHITECTURAL HISTORY SERIES · BOOK 1

7
Vienna: Secession, Wagner and the Road to Modernism

The Secession: 'To every age its art'

Wagner's public works: stations, a bank and a church

Wagner's school, and the economics of beauty

The style at city scale

1902: the Beethoven Exhibition as total artwork



Photo: HarkOlufs02, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 4.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Majolikahaus,_Wien,_Otto_Wagner.jpg

Vienna took the curve and put it on trial. The imperial capital of the Ringstrasse — that boulevard of revivalist parliaments, universities and opera houses — possessed in Otto Wagner (1841–1918) the style's most formidable theorist, and in a band of young secessionists its most disciplined revolutionaries. Wagner, professor at the Academy and architect of Vienna's new railway, had announced the programme in his book Modern Architecture (1896): 'Nothing that is not practical can be beautiful.' His own work performs the argument — ornament shrinking, year by year, into proportion, material and the honest bolt-head.

His Majolica House (1898–99) on the Linke Wienzeile is the hinge. A perfectly conventional apartment block in plan, it is wrapped in a skin of glazed ceramic tiles patterned with climbing flowers by Alois Ludwig: the ornament is quite literally a washable, weatherproof surface, industrial and decorative at once, art as specification. Next door, Wagner's own apartment house at Köstlergasse turns the same system sober. The lesson Vienna drew from Art Nouveau was not the curve but the surface — the idea that a modern building's beauty could live in its cladding, its lettering and its plan, and that everything else was negotiable.

The Secession: 'To every age its art'

In April 1897, nineteen artists and architects resigned from Vienna's official Künstlerhaus and founded the Secession, with Gustav Klimt as president. Their building, designed by the twenty-nine-year-old Joseph Maria Olbrich and opened in November 1898, is the movement's most perfect manifesto in stone: a white, cubic exhibition hall, almost windowless, crowned by a gilded openwork dome of laurel leaves — Viennese wits called it the golden cabbage — and inscribed with Ludwig Hevesi's motto: Der Zeit ihre Kunst, der Kunst ihre Freiheit — to every age its art, to art its freedom. Inside, movable walls made the gallery a neutral instrument; for the Beethoven Exhibition of 1902, Klimt painted his Beethoven Frieze around Max Klinger's statue, a total environment of painting, sculpture and architecture that survives as the Secession's treasure.

The Secession generation — Olbrich, Josef Hoffmann, Koloman Moser, the painter-designers of the Wiener Werkstätte (founded 1903) — subjected Art Nouveau to geometry. The tendril squared itself into the grid, the checkerboard, the black-and-white abstraction that became Vienna's signature. When Hoffmann built the Palais Stoclet in Brussels (1905–11) for the banker Adolphe Stoclet, with interiors by the Werkstätte and a dining room of Klimt mosaics, the result was a palace of marble planes and bronze trim in which the whiplash line has been completely ironed into luxurious modernity. UNESCO inscribed it in 2009 as a masterpiece of the Secession's maturity. Between the Secession Building of 1898 and the Stoclet of 1911 lies the shortest road in architectural history from Art Nouveau to modern design.



Photo: C.Stadler/Bwag, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 4.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Wien_-_Secessionsgeb%C3%A4ude.JPG

Wagner's public works: stations, a bank and a church

Wagner's own masterpieces of these years are public. The Karlsplatz pavilions of the Stadtbahn (1898–99) dress railway entrances in white marble panels, green steel and gilded sunflowers — infrastructure as jewellery, later dismantled, moved and finally restored to the square as the style's civic relics. The Austrian Postal Savings Bank (1904–06) hides a revolution behind a marble-veneered facade fastened with aluminium bolts that are frankly expressed as ornament: inside, a banking hall of glass bricks, exposed steel and warm-air columns, the most luminous machine for finance of its decade, and a founding monument of modern architecture. The Kirche am Steinhof (1904–07), the church of the Steinhof psychiatric hospital, completes the trilogy — a golden dome over an interior designed like a hygienic theatre, with angled walls for cleaning, a gently sloped floor for wheelchairs, and altar mosaics by Moser: Wagner insisting that even heaven be planned around use.

Vienna also supplied the movement's executioner. Adolf Loos, who had absorbed the Arts and Crafts in England and America, published 'Ornament and Crime' (written 1908; published in French in 1913), arguing that ornament was wasted labour and cultural atavism, and built the Looshaus (1909–11) opposite the imperial palace with a facade of aggressive plainness that scandalised the Emperor himself. Loos was wrong about ornament and right about economics — hand-carved richness was becoming unaffordable — and his polemic gave the next generation permission to discard the curve entirely. Chapter 16 follows the consequences.

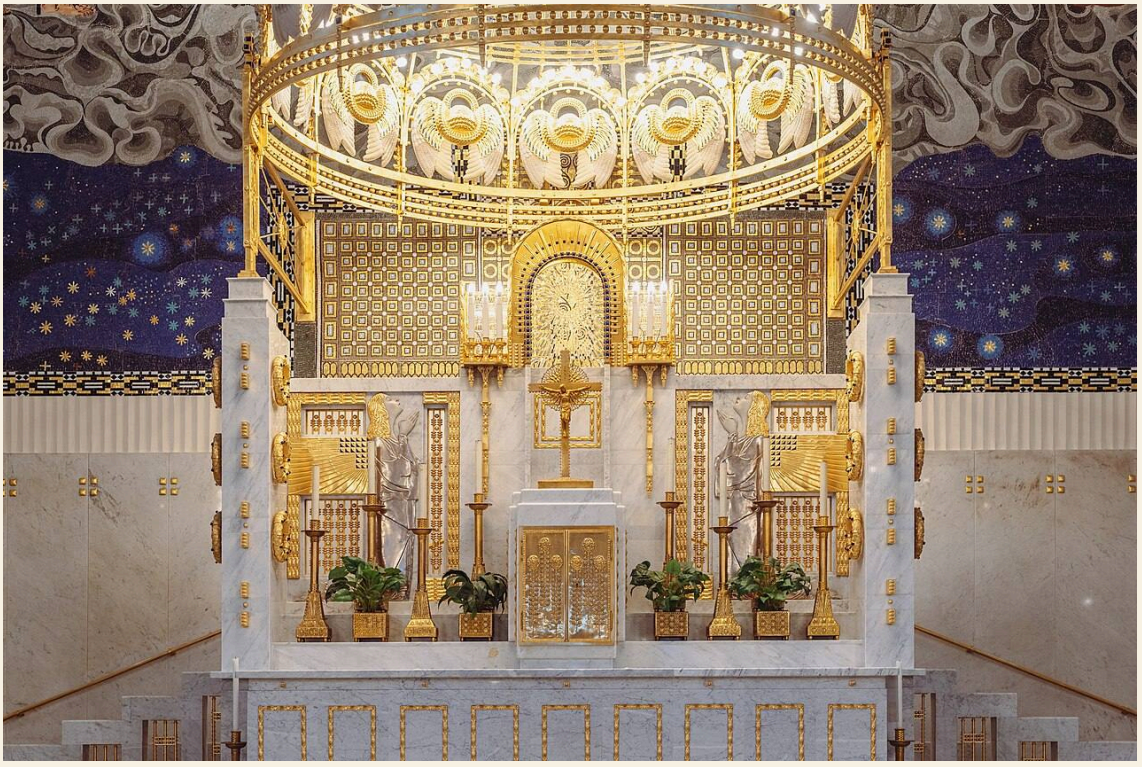


Photo: Flocci Nivis, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 4.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:20250503_Kirche_am_Steinhof_03.jpg

Wagner's school, and the economics of beauty

Wagner's deepest influence ran through his classroom. As professor at the Academy of Fine Arts from 1894 he trained the generation that would build modern Central Europe — Josef Hoffmann, Joseph Maria Olbrich (his assistant in practice), Jože Plečnik, who carried the teaching to Ljubljana and Prague, Jan Kotěra in Bohemia, and dozens more; the annual volumes of his students' designs were the style's most effective textbook. The Wagner School's doctrine — construction first, ornament as the disciplined accent of construction — is the bridge on which Art Nouveau crossed into the twentieth century without noticing the border.

The Wiener Werkstätte, founded in 1903 by Hoffmann, Koloman Moser and the banker Fritz Waerndorfer, attempted the style's economic salvation: workshops producing furniture, metalwork, jewellery, fashion and entire interiors 'from the teapot to the house', signed with the interlaced WW monogram. It made Vienna's design world-famous and never made Vienna's design profitable in proportion; luxury hand-production could not beat the department store at its own game, and the Werkstätte, twice refinanced, finally closed in 1932. Its rise and fall is Chapter 10's

argument in business form: the total work of art is the most expensive idea in design history, and every generation that revives it must solve its price all over again.

The style at city scale

Step back from the individual stations and the Stadtbahn becomes the style's largest single commission: an entire metropolitan railway — some thirty stations, with bridges, viaducts and cuttings in one consistent kit of parts — designed under Wagner's direction as the city's consulting architect from 1894. The network matters to this history because it proves the Secession style could operate at infrastructure scale: standardised, repeatable, maintained by a bureaucracy — the very conditions its critics claimed organic design could never meet. Vienna's U4 line still runs through Wagner's stations: the only Art Nouveau a million commuters use as a tool, daily, without noticing — which is perhaps the definition of a style finally absorbed into a city.

1902: the Beethoven Exhibition as total artwork

One exhibition deserves a paragraph of its own, because it is the purest surviving statement of what the Secession believed. For the spring of 1902 the association devoted its building to Beethoven: Max Klinger's polychrome statue of the composer as a Zeus-like genius stood in Olbrich's central hall, and around the walls Gustav Klimt painted his Beethoven Frieze — a thirty-four-metre procession of floating women, gorgons, sickness, poetry and a final embracing choir, executed in casein, gold leaf and inlaid stones on plaster. Josef Hoffmann designed the installation; Mahler, who conducted the opening's wind arrangement of the Ninth Symphony's finale, supplied the music's blessing. Painting, sculpture, architecture, design and music were not exhibited together; they were composed together, as one chord.

The frieze was painted for a temporary show and nearly lost with it — preserved by a collector, sold, divided, reacquired by the Austrian state and restored to the Secession's basement in the 1980s, where it now glows in a room built for it alone. Its survival arc — masterpiece, embarrassment, storage, treasure — is the style's whole afterlife in one object, and the frieze's gold, weightless eroticism remains the most reproduced image of Viennese modernity. When visitors today descend to that basement they are completing the exhibition of 1902, a century late.



Artwork: Gustav Klimt, via Wikimedia Commons (public domain). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Klimt_-_Beethovenfries_-_Mittelwand.jpg

ARCHITECTURAL HISTORY SERIES · BOOK 1

8

Glasgow: Mackintosh and the Discipline of the Grid

The Glasgow School of Art (1897–99; 1907–09)

Exile and the watercolours

The Four: Margaret and Frances Macdonald

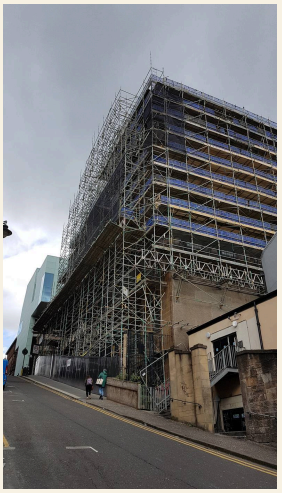


Photo: John a s, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 3.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Wfm_glasgow_school_of_art.jpg

The furthest translation of the style happened in a shipbuilding city on the Clyde. Glasgow — rich, smoky, Presbyterian, and building furiously — possessed an art school of unusual freedom under its director Francis Newbery, who encouraged his students to raid every European journal. Among them, Charles Rennie Mackintosh (1868–1928) and his circle, the painter-sisters Margaret and Frances Macdonald and Herbert MacNair — 'the Four' — fused the continental whiplash with Celtic revival imagery, Japanese restraint and a severity of grid that no continental designer would have dared. Where Brussels curves, Glasgow elongates: tall, thin, vertical compositions, stylised roses, ladder-back chairs of impossible height, white rooms touched with silver and amethyst.

The Glasgow Style was a European success and a local suspicion. The Four exhibited at the Vienna Secession in 1900 and in Turin in 1902 to acclaim — Mackintosh's furniture and interiors were arguably more influential in Austria and Germany than anything made there — while at home the work was patronised mainly by a few brave clients: the tea-room entrepreneur Catherine Cranston, for whom Mackintosh designed a chain of interiors culminating in the Willow Tea Rooms (1903), and the publisher Walter Blackie.

The Glasgow School of Art (1897–99; 1907–09)

Mackintosh's masterpiece won its competition in 1896 and rose in two campaigns on a steep site in Renfrew Street. The north facade is a working drawing made architecture: huge studio windows, sized and placed exactly by the daylight each room needs, held in a masonry grid stiffened with iron rails on which, tradition says, the students cleaned their brushes. The east end is solid, castle-like, Scottish baronial digested into pure massing; the west wing, added in the second campaign, carries the building's glory — the library, a two-storey forest of dark timber columns and galleries suspended in jewelled light, one of the great rooms of the century. The school shows Art Nouveau's structural rationalism at its most poetic: nothing is applied, everything is the plan and the light made visible. Fires in 2014 and, catastrophically, 2018 gutted the building during restoration; the library survives in memory, in drawings, and in the long debate over faithful reconstruction — a debate that is itself a lesson in what the style means to us now (Chapter 17).

The Hill House at Helensburgh (1902–04), built for Blackie, translates the manner to domestic life: a grey harled Scottish exterior of studied plainness, opening to interiors of white walls, stencilled roses, and furniture designed down to the wardrobes' interiors — Mackintosh is said to have advised the Blackies to leave behind anything that clashed, in the gentlest act of total-design tyranny on record. Glasgow's chapter closes the regional survey with a paradox the whole book keeps meeting: the style's most forward-looking designer was the one who ornamented least, and the city that formed him let him die, in 1928, working as a watercolourist in France, his revolution credited to the continent that had borrowed it.



Photo: Anthony O'Neil, via geograph.org.uk (CC BY-SA 2.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:The_Hill_House,_Helensburgh_-_geograph.org.uk_-_1570975.jpg

Exile and the watercolours

Mackintosh's last decades are the style's saddest biography and should not be hurried past. Commissions dried up after 1913 — the Glasgow manner was out of fashion, his perfectionism was expensive, and the war ended the tea-room world. He left Glasgow for London in 1915, designed studios in Chelsea and a famously uncompromising house-front at 78 Derngate, Northampton (1916) for the model-maker W. J. Bassett-Lowke — its interior a black-and-gold Secessionist jewel in a Northampton terrace — and worked increasingly as a textile designer. In 1923 the Mackintoshes withdrew to Port-Vendres in the French Pyrenees, where he painted the watercolours — landscapes and flowers rendered with mineral exactness — on which his late reputation first revived. He died of cancer in London in 1928, aged sixty, his ashes scattered off Port-Vendres. The city that would one day put his name on its airport said almost nothing; Vienna, which remembered 1900, sent the tributes. The Glasgow School of Art — twice burned, as this chapter has recorded — stands in our own century as the movement's most argued-over ruin, and the argument about its reconstruction is, fittingly, an argument about whether a total work of art can survive the loss of its totality.

The Four: Margaret and Frances Macdonald

The Glasgow Style was a collaboration, and its history has had to be re-credited. Margaret Macdonald (1864–1933) and her sister Frances (1873–1921), trained at the Glasgow School of Art, worked with Mackintosh and Herbert MacNair as 'the Four', producing the gesso panels, beaten-metal plaques, watercolours and embroidered hangings — elongated women among roses and moons — that gave the style its mystical register. Margaret married Mackintosh in 1900; their interiors thereafter are joint works in a sense the documents only partly record, and Mackintosh himself said it plainly: 'Margaret has genius, I have only talent.' The sisters' panels for the Turin exhibition of 1902 and the Wärndorfer music room in Vienna carried Glasgow's name across Europe as surely as any building.

The tea rooms complete the picture of the style at work in daily life. Catherine Cranston's establishments — Argyle Street, Buchanan Street, Ingram Street, and the Willow in Sauchiehall Street (1903) — gave respectable Glasgow, and especially its women, a public interior of art: white rooms, silver stencils, the famous high-backed chairs and the Room de Luxe glowing like a jewel box. Mackintosh's total design extended to cutlery, menus and waitresses' dresses. That the style's most complete British interiors were rooms for tea, run by a woman, designed substantially with a woman, is a fact Chapter 13 takes up — the new art and the new woman were contemporaries, and each used the other's spaces.

ARCHITECTURAL HISTORY SERIES · BOOK 1

9
The Wider Map: Jugendstil, Liberty, Riga and America

America: Sullivan, Tiffany and the parallel invention

Hungary, Bohemia and Finland: the style as national language

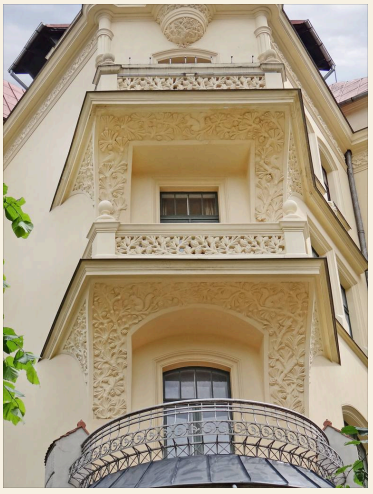


Photo: Jean-Pierre Dalbéra, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY 2.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Immeuble_art_nouveau_(Riga)_(7561800214).jpg

By 1900 the style had a branch office in nearly every European capital, and the variations map the continent's cultures with embarrassing precision. In Germany, Jugendstil kept the floral line but married it to reformist earnestness: Munich's journal Jugend (from 1896) named it; August Endell's Atelier Elvira in Munich (1897–98) sported a facade-sized plaster wave that was famous, photographed and eventually destroyed; and at Darmstadt, Grand Duke Ernst Ludwig of Hesse founded the Mathildenhöhe artists' colony (1899), where Olbrich — imported from Vienna — built a complete hill town of the new art, crowned by his Wedding Tower (1905–08) with its five gabled 'fingers'. Peter Behrens, painter turned architect there, designed his own house in the colony in 1901 and walked out of the style toward industrial design and the AEG factories — the Jugendstil's self-overcoming in one career.

In Italy the Stile Liberty — named for London's Liberty & Co., the style's great retail exporter — flowered latest and most floridly, showcased at the Turin exhibition of 1902 and built most richly in Turin, Milan and Palermo, where Ernesto Basile gave Sicilian villas and the Grand Hotel Villa Igiea (1899–1900) a Mediterranean accent of iron, fresco and majolica. In the Netherlands the manner met Berlage's rationalism and came out sober, brick-built, 'Nieuwe Kunst'. In Russia, 'Modern' produced Moscow masterpieces by Fyodor Shekhtel, all ceramic peacocks and rational plans for merchant princes. And in Riga, the empire's booming port raised the style's most concentrated urban legacy: some eight hundred Art Nouveau buildings, roughly a third of the historic centre (UNESCO, 1997), where Mikhail Eisenstein's facades on Alberta iela pile masks, sphinxes and garlands into a stone theatre of new money.

America: Sullivan, Tiffany and the parallel invention

The United States invented its own cousin. Louis Sullivan, the Chicago master of the steel-frame skyscraper, had developed by the 1890s an organic ornament of interlacing geometry and botany, theorised in his essay 'The Tall Office Building Artistically Considered' (1896) with the dictum that 'form ever follows function'. His Carson Pirie Scott Building (1899–1904) grids its upper floors in honest white terracotta and then erupts, at the pavement, into a bronze-green cast-iron entrance of unbelievable richness — the department store as cathedral door. Sullivan drank from some of the same sources as Horta — Viollet-le-Duc, Owen Jones's Grammar of Ornament, transcendentalist nature philosophy — and the resemblance is fraternity, not copying: Art Nouveau was the European dialect of a transatlantic language.

America's other contribution was light itself. Louis Comfort Tiffany's studios turned the style into glass: favrile glass lamps whose shades were designed substantially by Clara Driscoll and her 'Tiffany Girls' of the Women's Glass Cutting Department — the dragonfly and lily lamps that remain the style's most beloved objects in the United States. Bing sold Tiffany in Paris; Tiffany showed at the 1900 Exposition; the Atlantic exchange ran both ways. When the style waned, America metabolised it into the Prairie School and the Craftsman house, while Europe forgot. The wider map thus ends where the argument of this book began: Art Nouveau was never a Parisian fad with provincial echoes, but the first truly international design movement, carried by journals, exhibitions, catalogues and emigrant craftsmen — a rehearsal for the globalised design culture we now inhabit.



Photo: Ken Lund, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 2.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Carson,_Pirie,_Scott_and_Company_Building_(Sullivan_Center),_Chicago,_Illinois_(9179422705).jpg

Hungary, Bohemia and Finland: the style as national language

East and north, the style acquired a second job: inventing nations. In Budapest, Ödön Lechner (1845–1914) spent a career fusing the international line with Hungarian folk embroidery, Persian and Indian motifs, and the pyrogranite ceramics of the Zsolnay factory to forge a self-consciously Hungarian architecture — the Museum of Applied Arts (1893–96), its glazed roof a flower of coloured glass, and the Postal Savings Bank (1900–01) are its monuments. The establishment called him dangerous and denied him commissions and honours; posterity calls him the father of Hungarian modern architecture. The pattern — the new style as the costume in which a young nation recognises itself — repeats the Catalan story in another key.

In Prague, the Czech Secese crowned itself with the Municipal House (Obecní dům, 1905–12) by Antonín Balšánek and Osvald Polívka: concert hall, café and civic palace wrapped in mosaic, sculpture and a famous gable mosaic by Karel Špillar, with interiors to which Mucha himself contributed after his return. In Helsinki, the firm of Gesellius, Lindgren and Saarinen armoured Finnish identity in granite — the Pohjola Insurance Building (1899–1901), its bears and pine-cones carved from national bedrock, and the studio-community of Hvitträsk (1902) — a National Romanticism so close to Art Nouveau in date and spirit, and so distinct in its granite sobriety, that the two are best read as siblings raised in different climates. Add Kraków's Young Poland, where Wyspiański designed stained glass like manifestos, and the map is complete: by 1905 a traveller could cross Europe entirely inside the new art, changing dialect at every border.



Photo: Jorge Láscar, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY 2.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Lascar_Obecn%C3%AD_d%C5%AFm_(Municipal_House)_(4502264288).jpg

PLATES

Plate I — The Tassel Stair, Brussels



Photo: Henry Townsend, via Wikimedia Commons (public domain). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Tassel_House_stairway.JPG

The most consequential stair of the 1890s: Horta hangs a glazed dome over an open well and lets the iron railing grow, unbroken, from newel to cornice. Light falls through the plan's dark centre; the house's circulation becomes its ceremony.

PLATES

Plate II — The Secession Building, Vienna



Photo: C.Stadler/Bwag, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 4.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Wien_-_Secessionsgeb%C3%A4ude.JPG

Olbrich's exhibition temple of 1898: a white cube, a laurel dome of gilded iron leaves, and ornament rationed like ammunition. Vienna's revolution would be fought with geometry, not tendrils — this building is the treaty between the two.

PLATES

Plate III — The Hôtel Solvay Stair, Brussels

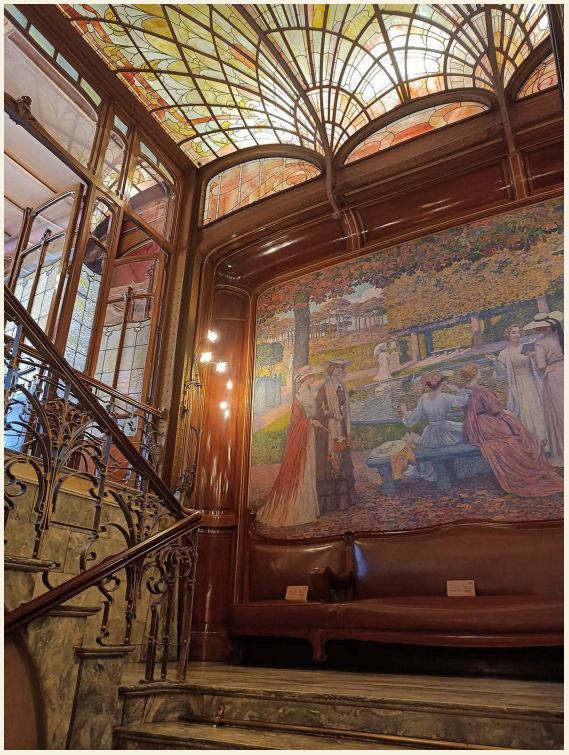


Photo: Brigade Piron, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY 3.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:H%C3%B4tel_Solvay_-_Main_Stairs.jpg

Mahogany, marble, iron and light composed as one chord in Horta's most sumptuous surviving interior — preserved, with its furniture and fittings, as the period's most complete total work of art.

PLATES

Plate IV — Inside Casa Batlló, Barcelona



Photo: Sara Terrones, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 4.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:CasaBatll%C3%B3_NobleFloor_saloon_stainedglass.jpg

Gaudí remodelled not walls but weather: mushroom fireplaces, swirling ceilings and light wells graded from deep blue to white, so that a bourgeois apartment breathes like a sea cave.

PLATES

Plate V — Klimt's Beethoven Frieze, Vienna



Artwork: Gustav Klimt, via Wikimedia Commons (public domain). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Klimt_-_Beethovenfries_-_Mittelwand.jpg

Painted for the Secession's Beethoven exhibition of 1902 and nearly destroyed with it, the frieze survives in the Secession's basement: gold leaf, casein and inlaid stone carrying humanity's procession toward joy.

PLATES

Plate VI — Hospital de Sant Pau, Barcelona



Photo: Julian Lupyan, via Wikimedia Commons (CC0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Hospital_de_Sant_Pau,_Fa%C3%A7ade,_Barcelona.jpg

Domènech i Montaner's garden city of healing: forty-four pavilions of brick, tile and glass, a working hospital built as a Modernista manifesto and now a UNESCO-listed museum.

PART III

Making and Meaning

Iron, glass, ceramic and craft: the materials and workshops of the style, the houses it remade room by room, the women who made and commissioned it, and six buildings read slowly.

ARCHITECTURAL HISTORY SERIES · BOOK 1

10

Materials and Making: How the Curve Was Built

Construction: old bones, new skin — and sometimes new bones

Concrete: the style's secret modernity



Photo: Eric Polk, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 4.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Tiffany_Studios_-_Eighteen-Light_Lily_Lamp_-_HNT.jpg

Art Nouveau is best understood as a negotiation between the hand and the machine, and its materials list is the treaty. First, iron — cast and wrought. Cast iron, poured into sand moulds taken from a carved pattern, could reproduce any tendril the architect drew, at the cost of a printed page once the pattern existed; Guimard's Métro stalks and the Castel Béranger's gate are castings, repeated and combined like type. Wrought iron, hammered hot by smiths, gave the one-off flourish: Horta's railings, the balconies of Casa Milà forged in Barcelona workshops (some reworked from sheet and scrap under Jujol's eye). Second, glass — in sheets large enough to make shopfronts and the Tassel's roof, and in colour: opalescent American glass, French cameo glass from Gallé and Daum, stained glass reimagined as painting in light. Third, ceramic: the tiled skins of the Majolica House and the Lavirotte Building, Gaudí's trencadís of broken glazes, faience fireplaces, stoneware by Bigot — clay as the style's weatherproof colour.

Then the warm materials: bentwood, steam-bent by Thonet's Vienna factories into the continuous curve (the famous Chair No. 14 predates the style and made its cafés possible); marquetry and carved fruitwoods in Majorelle's Nancy furniture; mosaic — tesserae of glass and stone flowing across Horta's floors; sgraffito, the scratched-plaster mural technique revived on Brussels facades; and everywhere, the new electric light, which designers housed in glass flowers, turning the bulb — that naked industrial fact — into a bouquet. Underpinning all of it was drawing: the Art Nouveau architect was a draughtsman of genius or he was nothing, because every tradesman on the building took his instruction from full-size cartoons of curves that exist in no pattern book.

Construction: old bones, new skin — and sometimes new bones

Honesty requires the admission that most Art Nouveau buildings are conventionally built: load-bearing brick or stone walls, timber or iron-joisted floors, a revolutionary skin and interior over a traditional carcass. The style's structural adventures happen at specific, thrilling points: Horta's exposed iron columns and the open, top-lit plan they permit; Guimard's prefabricated castings; the steel frame inside Domènech's Palau de la Música, which is why its walls can be glass; Wagner's bolted marble veneer on the Postsparkasse — cladding confessed as cladding; Gaudí's catenary vaults and leaning columns, structure derived from hanging-chain models and destined for the Sagrada Família's stone forest. Early reinforced concrete appears at the edges of the story — Guimard experimented boldly, and Hennebique's system was spreading through France — but the style's true structural legacy is conceptual: the free plan inside Casa Milà's self-supporting facade, and the doctrine, inherited from Viollet-le-Duc, that construction should be visible and beautiful. Modernism kept the doctrine and dropped the decoration.

Modern equivalents must be named separately, as our hub discipline requires. Today's 'Art Nouveau' productions — laser-cut steel screens, CNC-milled ornament, cast-resin curves, printed ceramic transfers — reproduce the style's line without its constructional logic or its labour economy, and belong to the history of revival, not of the style itself (Chapter 17). A contemporary architect honouring Art Nouveau honestly would not copy its curves but its method: structure as ornament, the whole interior as one design, ornament generated from the building's own system. That distinction — style as method versus style as wallpaper — is the most useful thing this book can teach a practising designer.

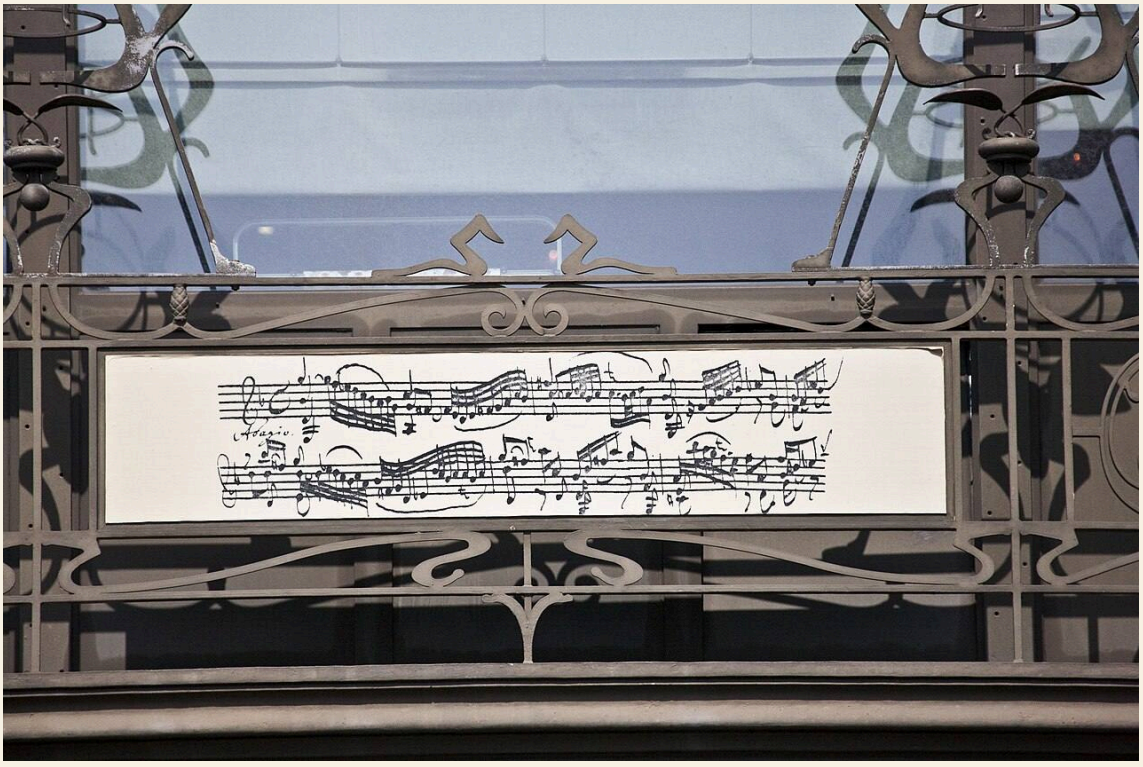


Photo: William Murphy, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 2.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Musical_Instrument_Museum_(Brussels)_(4645954733).jpg

Concrete: the style's secret modernity

One material in the story points past the style itself. Reinforced concrete — patented in systems by Monier and Hennebique in the 1890s — offered the curve in its cheapest, strongest form, and the avant-garde noticed. Anatole de Baudot, Viollet-le-Duc's pupil, built the church of Saint-Jean-de-Montmartre in Paris (1894–1904) as a concrete skeleton dressed in brick and ceramic: the first church of the material, denounced, prosecuted for thinness, and still standing. In 1902–03 Auguste Perret, trained in the classical atelier and converted to the frame, raised 25bis rue Franklin in Passy — an apartment house whose concrete frame is expressed on the facade and then clothed, pointedly, in floral ceramic tiles by Bigot, so that the tenants would not have to look at raw concrete. The building is the exact midpoint of this book's story: Art Nouveau's skin on modernism's bones. Perret's pupils included Le Corbusier. The line from Guimard's castings through Perret's frame to the free facade of the 1920s is not a metaphor; it is a staff list.



Photo: Jean-Pierre Dalbéra, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY 2.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:La_Mathildenh%C3%B6he,_colline_jugendstil_(Darmstadt)_(7882270018).jpg

ARCHITECTURAL HISTORY SERIES · BOOK 1

11

The Total Interior: Furniture, Glass, Jewellery and the Poster

Glass and jewellery: the style in the hand

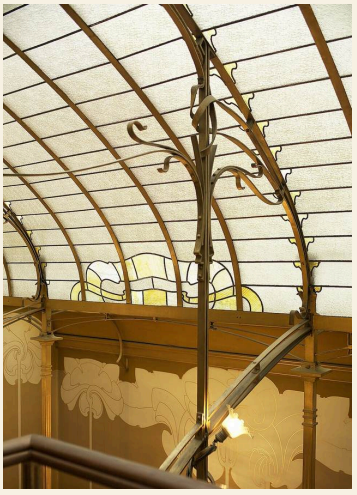


Photo: via Wikimedia Commons (CC0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Staircase_of_the_Victor_Horta_own_house_(25,_rue_Am%C3%A9ricaine,_1060,_Brussels).jpg

Art Nouveau began as architecture and immediately overflowed into everything architecture contains. The doctrine of the total work of art meant that a Horta interior left nothing to chance: the architect designed the stair, the stair's carpet, the chairs, the piano, the lamp above the piano and, in the case of the Hôtel Solvay, coordinated the paintings too. This chapter follows the style indoors, because its influence on the twentieth century ran as much through the object as through the building — and because the objects, being portable, carried the style to cities that never built a single whiplash facade.

Furniture first. In Brussels, Horta's pupil Gustave Serrurier-Bovy and the master himself bent wood and brass into furniture that grows rather than stands. In Paris, the 'Art Nouveau Bing' style of Eugène Gaillard and Georges de Feure furnished Bing's 1900 pavilion with rooms of pale wood and attenuated line. In Nancy, Louis Majorelle built an empire of marquetry cabinets whose floral inlay is furniture as landscape painting, while his contemporary Jacques Grüber set the city's windows. In Vienna the line straightened: Hoffmann and Moser designed furniture as architecture in miniature — the grid, the cube, the famous Sitzmaschine armchair that adjusts like a machine for sitting. And in Glasgow, Mackintosh's high-backed chairs turned dining into ceremony, their ladder silhouettes more sculpture than seating, designed for rooms — Miss Cranston's tea rooms above all — that functioned as total environments for the radical new ritual of respectable public leisure.

Glass and jewellery: the style in the hand

Glass was the style's miracle material. Émile Gallé in Nancy layered and acid-etched cameo glass with flowers, insects and Symbolist poetry until the vase became a manifesto; his rivals the Daum brothers industrialised the poetry without quite killing it. Lalique — René Lalique, trained jeweller — dissolved the boundary between glass and gem, making jewellery of horn, enamel and dragonfly wings that treated a jewel's value as artistry rather than carat, then, after 1905, carried the sensibility into perfume bottles and, eventually, the glass architecture of the Deco age. In America, Tiffany's favrile glass did parallel work (Chapter 8). A style that can be recognised equally in a cathedral of music and a brooch has achieved something no revival ever managed: a complete material culture.

And the poster — the style's cheapest and fastest ambassador. Jules Chéret had made the colour lithograph an art; Alphonse Mucha, a Czech working in Paris, gave it its canonical form in a single night, when his poster for Sarah Bernhardt's Gismonda (unveiled 1 January 1895) — the actress full-length, hieratic, in a frame like a Byzantine icon — stopped Paris in its tracks and won him a six-year contract. The 'Mucha style' of flowing hair, floral halos and mosaic pattern became so identified with the movement that in France the whole style was sometimes named for its posters. Toulouse-Lautrec's flatter, crueller lithographs, Privat-Livemont's absinthe goddesses in Brussels, the Beggarstaffs' reductions in London: the street gallery taught the public to read the curve before it ever entered an Art Nouveau room. Any complete history must record that this architecture of plants and iron was also, inseparably, an architecture of paper.



Artwork: Gustav Klimt, via Wikimedia Commons (public domain). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Klimt_-_Beethovenfries_-_Mittelwand.jpg

ARCHITECTURAL HISTORY SERIES · BOOK 1

12

The House Remade: A Room-by-Room Anatomy

Upstairs: hygiene, privacy and the modern bathroom

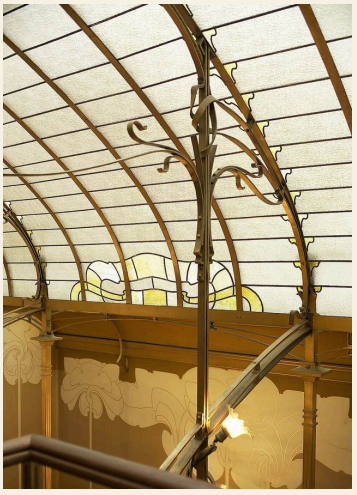


Photo: via Wikimedia Commons (CC0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Staircase_of_the_Victor_Horta_own_house_(25,_rue_Am%C3%A9ricaine,_1060,_Brussels).jpg

To feel what the style changed, walk through one of its houses slowly, room by room. Begin at the street door, where the revolution announces itself in miniature: the bell push, the letterbox, the house number and the door furniture are designed as a set, frequently in the architect's own hand — Guimard's foundry sold door furniture by catalogue so that even a modest apartment could begin correctly. The vestibule that follows is not a passage but a decompression chamber between street and interior: mosaic or tiled floor (washable, patterned like a carpet in stone), a coat-stand grown from the wall, and the first controlled view — through glazed doors — of the stair. Everything in the Brussels hôtel is organised to make this sequence feel inevitable.

The stair hall is the house's heart and its machine for light. Horta's device — an open well crowned with glass, the stair doubling back in a flowing line — distributes daylight to the plan's dark centre and turns the daily act of climbing into ceremony. Around it, the reception rooms unfold with a new informality: the salon and dining room connected by wide glazed openings, a winter garden or conservatory interposed between house and yard so that nature is admitted in a frame, and everywhere the fitted, built-in furniture — sideboards, bookcases, benches — that the total-design architect drew into the walls. The dining room, the era's theatre of family status, receives the fullest treatment: at the Hôtel Solvay, table, chairs, sideboard, lights and the very silver belong to one commission.

Upstairs: hygiene, privacy and the modern bathroom

The private floors register the century's other revolution — hygiene. The Art Nouveau house is among the first to treat the bathroom as a designed room rather than a cupboard of tin tubs: tiled walls, fitted sanitary ware, hot water, and in Wagner's Vienna the frankly modern fitted bathroom as a selling point of the Majolica House. Bedrooms soften the style into textiles and pale wood; the child's room and the servant's room, at the top of the house, receive at least the honesty of light and air from the plan's central well. The kitchen, still a servants' domain, is planned with a rigour the Beaux-Arts house reserved for its salons — Horta's service stairs and pantries are little essays in logistics.

Two larger lessons hide in the anatomy. The first is that the style's famous totality was a solution to a real problem: the speculative builder's house arrived as a shell of standard parts, and the Art Nouveau interior was a technology for making it personal — plan, light and furniture tuned to one family. The second is that the type was adaptable: the same devices scale from the Solvay palace to Guimard's catalogue-furnished flats, which is why the style could furnish both the museum-piece interior and the ordinary bourgeois street. When later chapters record the style's fall, remember the stair hall: what fell was not a fashion of curves but a way of organising domestic life, and pieces of it — the open plan, the fitted kitchen, the designed bathroom, the house tuned to its light — never fell at all.

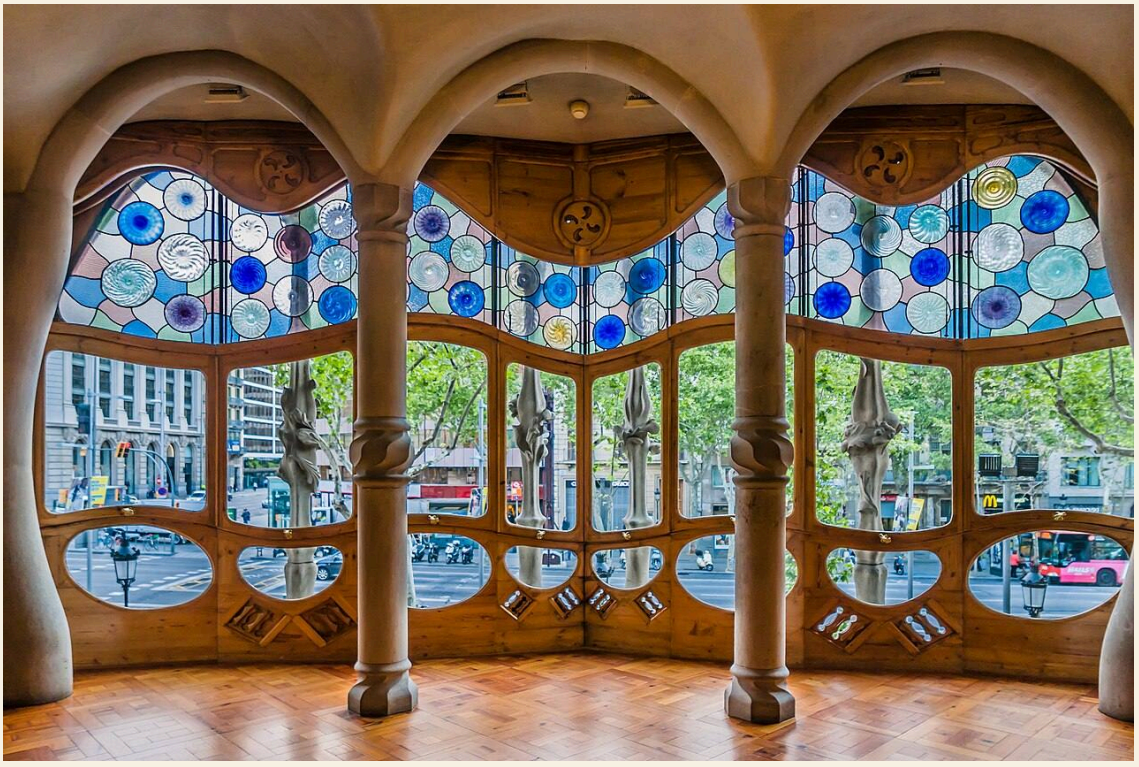


Photo: Sara Terrones, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 4.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:CasaBatll%C3%B3_NobleFloor_saloon_stainedglass.jpg

ARCHITECTURAL HISTORY SERIES · BOOK 1

13

The New Woman and the New Art: Makers, Patrons, Rooms of Their Own

Patrons and the politics of the tea room



Photo: Eric Polk, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 4.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Tiffany_Studios_-_Eighteen-Light_Lily_Lamp_-_HNT.jpg

The standard history of Art Nouveau was long written as a procession of men, and the record does not support it. The style's first spaces for respectable female public life — the tea room, the department store, the ladies' club — were among its most innovative interiors; its signature objects were designed, in documented numbers, by women whose names were filed under their employers'; and several of its most consequential patrons were women deploying fortunes of their own. A complete history restores these makers to their work, not as a gesture but because the buildings cannot be explained without them.

Begin with the makers. Clara Driscoll, head of Tiffany's Women's Glass Cutting Department from 1892, designed — as her letters, published a century later, establish — many of the studio's most famous lamps, including the dragonfly shade that won a bronze medal at Paris in 1900; her 'Tiffany Girls' selected, cut and soldered the glass, and struck, successfully, for equal pay in 1903. In Glasgow, Margaret and Frances Macdonald were not muses but co-authors of the style (Chapter 8 gives their work its place). In Vienna, the Werkstätte employed women designers and craftswomen across its workshops, and in Paris, the seamstress-turned-decorator's world of the grands magasins trained thousands more. The point is not that the style was secretly feminist — its imagery of femme-fleur could be as conventional as any salon painting — but that its production was substantially female, and its archives, read carefully, say so.

Patrons and the politics of the tea room

Catherine Cranston, who built a Glasgow tea-room empire and commissioned Mackintosh across twenty years, was a businesswoman of the first rank operating in a trade — temperance refreshment — that addressed itself to women shoppers and workers; her rooms were designed as total artworks because she understood environments as instruments of respectability and pleasure. In Barcelona, the ladies of the Palau de la Música's Orfeó; in Vienna, the salonnières and the women of the Frauenkunst; in Paris, Sarah Bernhardt herself — commissioner of Mucha's posters and of Lalique's fantastical stage jewels, and a sculptor's pupil in her own right — stand for a class of patrons without whom the style's geography is unintelligible. The dancer Loïe Fuller completes the circuit between patronage and form: her serpentine dances under electric light, performed inside a theatre designed in her image at the 1900 Exposition, were the whiplash line enacted by a body — and her stage technology, patented and toured worldwide, was design engineering of the first order.

The sober conclusion is also the interesting one: Art Nouveau's interiors were among the first designed environments of modern female life — neither the parlour nor the palace, but the tea room, the store, the studio and the exhibition — and the style's reputation for 'femininity', deployed by critics as an insult, was in part an accurate report of who its new public was. Histories that leave the women out do not merely omit names; they misunderstand the buildings.



Artwork: Alphonse Mucha, via Wikimedia Commons (public domain). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Alphonse_Mucha_-_Poster_for_Victorien_Sardou%27s_Gismonda_starring_Sarah_Bernhardt.jpg

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14
Six Buildings in Depth

1 · Hôtel Tassel, Brussels (1893–94) — Victor Horta

2 · Castel Béranger, Paris (1895–98) — Hector Guimard

3 · Casa Batlló, Barcelona (1904–06) — Antoni Gaudí

4 · Secession Building, Vienna (1897–98) — Joseph Maria Olbrich

5 · Majolica House, Vienna (1898–99) — Otto Wagner

6 · Hôtel Solvay, Brussels (1894–98) — Victor Horta



Photo: Henry Townsend, via Wikimedia Commons (public domain). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Tassel_House_stairway.JPG

Surveys persuade; buildings prove. This chapter takes six works already met in the regional chapters and slows down over each of them — commission, site, plan, construction, and the specific reason each one altered the course of the style. Read in sequence, they also tell the story in miniature: a private interior that invents a language (Tassel), an apartment house that industrialises it (Castel Béranger), a remodelling that perfects it (Casa Batlló), a manifesto that disciplines it (the Secession Building), an apartment house that dissolves it into modern cladding (the Majolica House), and a palace that prices it (the Hôtel Solvay). Dates and attributions follow the institutional sources listed at the end of the book; where a building can be visited, it still can be — the surest verification of everything claimed here.

1 · Hôtel Tassel, Brussels (1893–94) — Victor Horta

Commission: a town house for Émile Tassel, professor at the Université libre de Bruxelles and an executive of the Solvay company, on a narrow plot at 6 rue Paul-Émile Janson. Horta's answer is a lesson in making restriction sing. The facade, in stone with iron dressings, stacks a ground floor, a projecting central oriel and a rhythm of windows that already bends the classical tripartition without breaking decorum. The plan turns on the entrance sequence: a vestibule, then the famous octagonal hall where the stair rises — mosaic underfoot in ochre and green tendrils, a garden of iron overhead. The stair is not in the house; the house is around the stair. Rooms borrow its light through glazed partitions; the winter garden extends it; structure everywhere performs double duty as drawing.

Why it matters: the Tassel is the first building in which every Art Nouveau principle is present at full strength — open plan around light, exposed structure as ornament, ornament as one continuous drawn system, total design down to the furniture — four years before the style had a generally accepted name. Its limits are also instructive: it is a private, expensive, unrepeatable object, dependent on craftsmen executing one man's drawings. The whole subsequent history of the style is an attempt to keep the Tassel's fire while escaping its economics. UNESCO World Heritage since 2000.

2 · Castel Béranger, Paris (1895–98) — Hector Guimard

Commission: thirty-six rental apartments on a corner site in Passy for a widowed investor, Madame Fournier. Guimard, not yet thirty and fresh from his conversion in Brussels, treats the block as a botanical specimen. The street walls mix stone, red brick, sandstone and cast iron in shifting bands; windows proliferate in shapes — round, pointed, rectangular, mushroomed — as if the facade were growing at different rates; the balconies swell like fruit. The entrance gate, cast iron in a single interlaced drawing, condenses the whole building into one gesture and became the style's postcard. Inside, Guimard designed the apartments' fireplaces, papers and hardware with the same hand.

Why it matters: the Castel scales the Brussels interior idea up to the speculative apartment house, the characteristic building of the modern city, and it does so industrially — its ironwork comes from foundry patterns, reproducible and ordered by catalogue. When the building won the City of Paris facade prize in 1898 it certified Art Nouveau as fit for the street, not only the salon. The contrast with the Tassel is the contrast between the style's two futures: the unique total interior, and the branded, cast, repeatable 'Style Guimard' that would colonise the Métro. Both futures are Guimard's and Horta's common invention, divided between two temperaments.

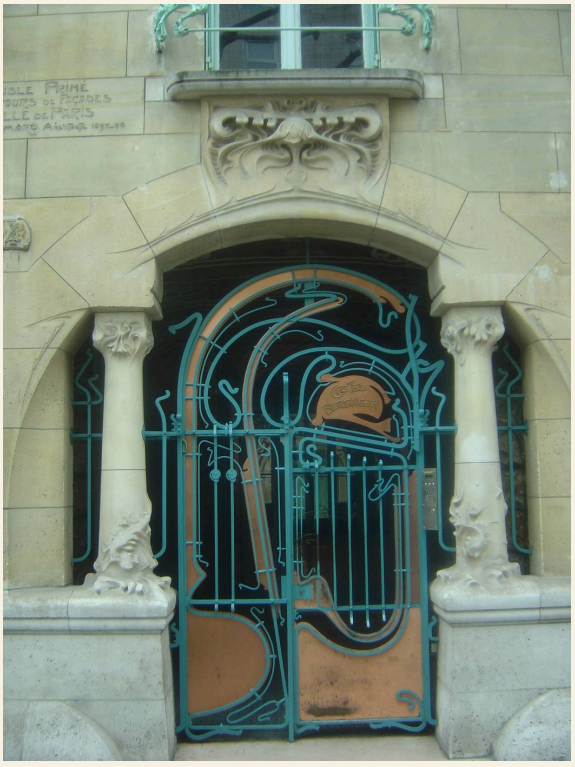


Photo: DIMSFIKAS, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 3.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Art_Nouveau_entrance_to_Castel_Beranger,_Paris_-_2011.jpg

3 · Casa Batlló, Barcelona (1904–06) — Antoni Gaudí

Commission: the radical remodelling of an existing 1875 apartment house on the Passeig de Gràcia for Josep Batlló, textile manufacturer, in direct competition with the neighbouring houses by Puig i Cadafalch and Domènech i Montaner. Gaudí kept the bones and replaced everything else. The facade: a stone skin of bone-like mullions, a field of blue-green trencadís that changes with the light like water, mask balconies, and a roof that is a dragon's back in glazed scales, with a four-armed cross for its crest. The plan: a central light-well enlarged and tiled in grading blues so that every floor receives equal daylight — the higher the flat, the lighter the tile — with windows whose wooden ventilators breathe without opening. The noble floor: a suite of rooms without a straight line, culminating in the saloon's window-wall of stained-glass discs and the mushroom fireplace nook, architecture as anatomy.

Why it matters: Casa Batlló is the fullest demonstration that Art Nouveau's ornament was a system of environmental intelligence — light, air, water run-off, thermal mass — wearing the mask of fantasy. Every apparently whimsical device is working. It is also the style's most persuasive argument that remodelling, not new construction, can produce masterpieces: a lesson our own century of adaptive reuse keeps relearning. UNESCO World Heritage since 2005 (inscribed 2005 as part of the extended Works of Antoni Gaudí).



Photo: Sara Terrones, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 4.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:CasaBatllo_rooftop_chimneys_dragon.jpg

4 · Secession Building, Vienna (1897–98) — Joseph Maria Olbrich

Commission: a permanent exhibition gallery for a breakaway artists' association that did not yet own a chair. Olbrich, twenty-nine, a former Wagner assistant, gave them a manifesto that could be built for 75,000 crowns: a near-windowless white cube on a city plot, its entrance flanked by planters and topped by the association's name, its roof crowned with an openwork sphere of gilded laurel — 2,500 leaves and 311 berries of iron, the 'golden cabbage' that Vienna laughed at and then adopted as a landmark. The side walls carry masks of the three arts and owls by Koloman Moser; the inscription, 'To every age its art, to art its freedom', turned a gallery into a creed.

Why it matters: the Secession Building proves the style could do austerity. Inside, Olbrich's movable partition walls invented the flexible white gallery that museums still use; the building's fame rests not on applied decoration but on proportion, symbol and one magnificent gesture in gilded iron. It is also the style's institutional turn: not a house or a shop but the headquarters of a movement, architecture as the flag of an association. Bombed and burned in 1945, it was restored (most completely in 1985–86) — its white cube and golden dome now serve as the period's most recognisable silhouette after Casa Batlló's roof.



Photo: C.Stadler/Bwag, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 4.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Wien_-_Secessionsgeb%C3%A4ude.JPG

5 · Majolica House, Vienna (1898–99) — Otto Wagner

Commission: a speculative apartment house at Linke Wienzeile 40, beside the Naschmarkt, for a developer — with Wagner's own city residence in the twin building next door. The plan is a standard Viennese rental floor; the revolution is entirely at the surface. The whole facade is clad in majolica tiles — glazed ceramic, floral-patterned by Alois Ludwig — chosen, Wagner said, because Vienna's soot could be washed from them with water: beauty as maintenance strategy. The iron balconies and the lift cage inside carry the floral theme in metal, and the bathrooms were among the first in Vienna designed as modern fitted rooms.

Why it matters: the Majolica House is the precise point where Art Nouveau becomes modern architecture. Ornament is not abolished but industrialised — flat, repeatable, durable, honest about being a skin. Wagner's students took the lesson; within a decade the skin itself would be argued away, but the twentieth century's cladding systems, curtain walls and panelised facades all descend from this flowery apartment house and its author's heretical proposition that nothing impractical can be beautiful. It also quietly refutes the caricature of the style as impractical: the building has been continuously inhabited, and easily cleaned, for over 120 years.



Photo: HarkOlufs02, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 4.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Majolikahaus,_Wien,_Otto_Wagner.jpg

6 · Hôtel Solvay, Brussels (1894–98) — Victor Horta

Commission: the Brussels palace of Armand Solvay, heir to the soda-process fortune, on the avenue Louise — with a budget that contemporaries described as unlimited and a brief that amounted to a blank cheque drawn on Europe's craft industries. Horta organised the house around its ceremonial stair, lit by a glazed canopy and hung with Théo van Rysselberghe's pointillist landscape 'The Reading'; around it he layered mahogany, onyx, marble, bronze and custom everything — carpets, lamps, door furniture, even the house's heating grilles drawn into the system. The facade, in stone with a great curving oriel, keeps the palace's secrets like a good servant.

Why it matters: the Solvay is the control experiment for the Tassel. Same architect, same city, five years on — but with money as no object, and the result shows what the style was reaching for when economics allowed: not more ornament, but more unity, achieved at a level of finish that makes the house read as a single cast object. It survived the century as offices, a fashion house and a museum-in-waiting, and since 2021 it has opened to visitors as one of the four UNESCO-listed Horta town houses. Stand in its stair hall and the argument of Chapter 16 becomes visible: nothing here failed artistically. What failed, in 1905 as now, was the invoice.

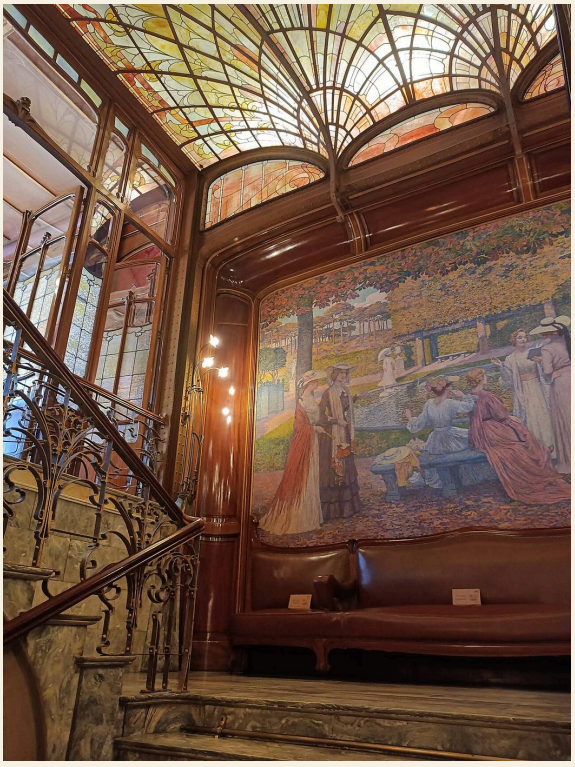


Photo: Brigade Piron, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY 3.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:H%C3%B4tel_Solvay_-_Main_Stairs.jpg

PART IV

Reading and Afterlives

The five-sign field method, the fall, the long embarrassment, the resurrection — and what the style still has to teach the people who design buildings now.

ARCHITECTURAL HISTORY SERIES · BOOK 1

15

Reading Art Nouveau: The Five Signs in the Field

A worked example: reading the Secession Building

Nouveau, Deco, Arts and Crafts: a three-way check

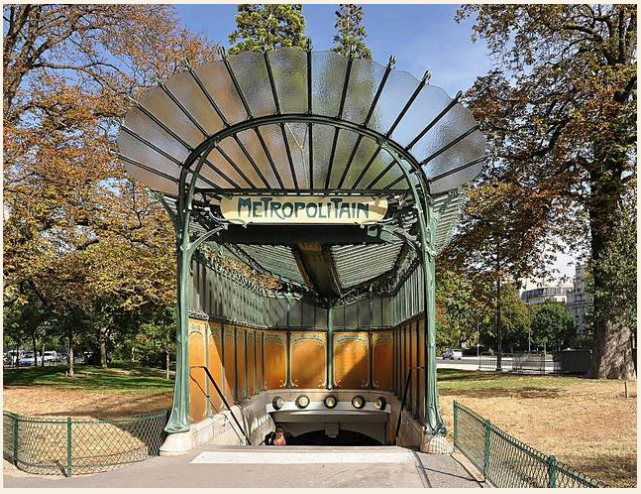


Photo: Moonik, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 3.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Metro_station_entrance_(%C3%A9dicule_Guimard)_Porte_Dauphine_Paris_16e_002.jpg

1. The whiplash line

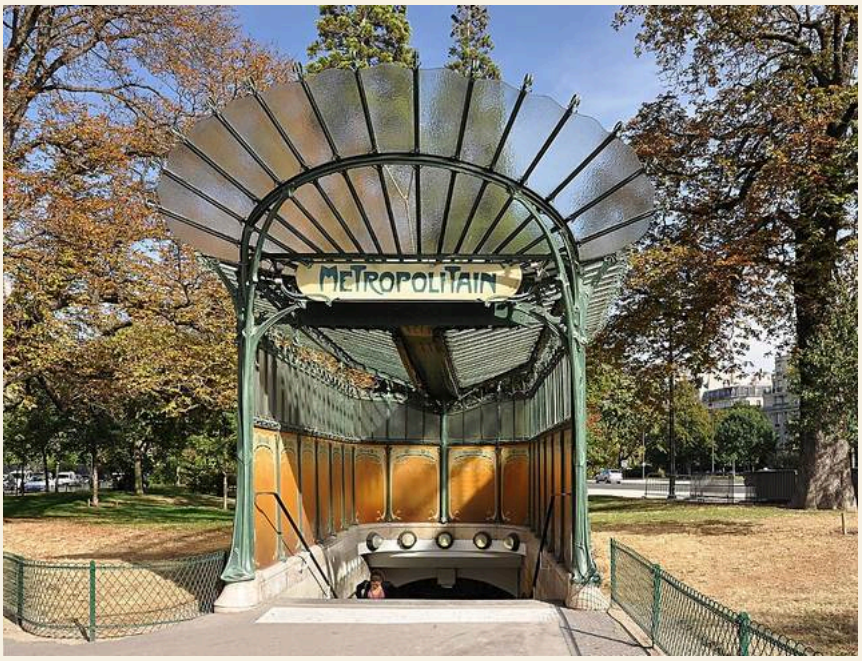


Photo: Moonik, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 3.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Metro_station_entrance_(%C3%A9dicule_Guimard)_Porte_Dauphine_Paris_16e_002.jpg

Lines swell, whip and taper like plant stems, asymmetrical and never mechanically repeated, across iron, glass, stone and lettering.

Limit: Curves alone also occur in Baroque and Rococo; the Nouveau line is thinner, faster and grows out of the structure rather than sitting on it.

2. Structure as ornament



Photo: Moonik, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 3.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Metro_station_entrance_(%C3%A9dicule_Guimard)_Porte_Dauphine_Paris_16e_002.jpg

Slender iron columns, brackets and balustrades stay visible and flower into decoration instead of hiding behind masonry or plaster.

Limit: Exposed iron also appears in purely industrial buildings of the period; look for the moment the structure starts to bloom.

3. The total interior



Photo: via Wikimedia Commons (CC0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Staircase_of_the_Victor_Horta_own_house_(25,_rue_Am%C3%A9ricaine,_1060,_Brussels).jpg

Stair, mosaic floor, stained glass, furniture, lights and handles share the same motifs, designed together for one room sequence.

Limit: Later sympathetic refurbishment can imitate a total interior convincingly; check the plan and the light, not only the objects.

4. The asymmetrical facade



Photo: Jaume Meneses, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 2.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Casa_Batll%C3%B3_(Barcelona)_-_24.jpg

Windows differ in size and shape floor by floor, bays bow outward, and ornament concentrates around doors and balconies rather than spreading evenly.

Limit: Asymmetry alone is common in vernacular building and proves little; it must be composed, deliberate asymmetry.

5. Nature, stylised

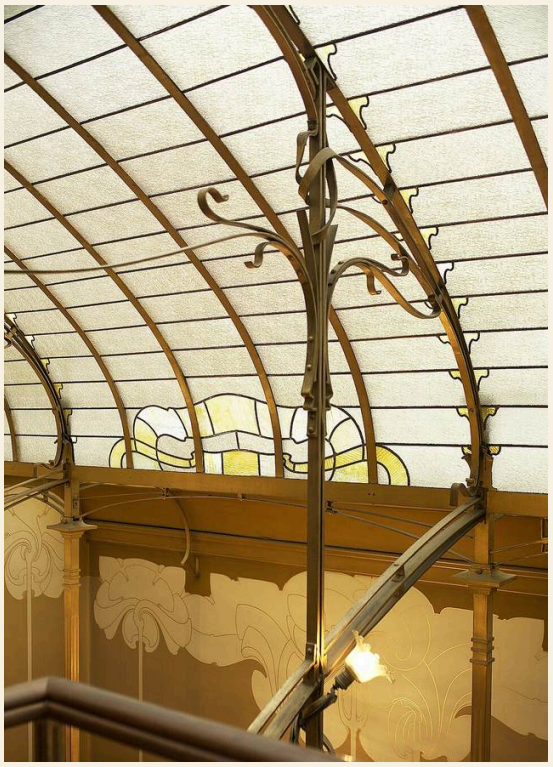


Photo: via Wikimedia Commons (CC0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Staircase_of_the_Victor_Horta_own_house_(25,_rue_Am%C3%A9ricaine,_1060,_Brussels).jpg

Irises, dragonflies, peacocks, stems and sea forms are flattened into pattern and line rather than carved as realistic naturalistic sculpture.

Limit: Realistic floral carving belongs equally to Gothic Revival work; Nouveau nature is always on its way to becoming geometry.

Everything in this book converges on a practical skill: standing in front of an unfamiliar building and knowing whether you are looking at Art Nouveau. Our Architectural History hub teaches a five-sign method for every style; here is the method deepened for this one, with the failure modes that catch out beginners. The rule of the method is that no single sign decides anything: let the five vote together, and let date and place arbitrate ties.

Sign one: the whiplash curve. Look for lines that swell and taper asymmetrically — in ironwork first, then in stone dressings, window shapes and lettering. Failure mode: Rococo and Baroque curves are symmetrical and shell-like; the whiplash is a single gesture, drawn once, like a signature. Sign two: structure as ornament. Slender iron columns, brackets and balconies presented proudly, often flowering at their joints. Failure mode: purely industrial iron — a railway shed's trusses are structure without the ornamental intention; in Art Nouveau the joint itself blossoms. Sign three: the total interior. Through the door, check whether stair, floor, glass, handles and furniture speak one language. Failure mode: later renovations in period taste can imitate the effect; look for the plan's integration, which cannot be faked by furniture.

Sign four: the asymmetrical facade. Windows vary floor by floor; bays bow; ornament concentrates at the entrance and thins as it climbs. Failure mode: vernacular asymmetry is accidental; Art Nouveau asymmetry is composed, balanced like a Japanese print. Sign five: stylised nature. Irises, dragonflies, peacocks, poppies — flattened into pattern, never carved as botanical illustration. Failure mode: Gothic Revival carving is naturalistic and moralised; Art Nouveau nature is sensual and abstracted toward pure line. Two supporting witnesses: materials and craft — exposed iron with glass, ceramic tile, mosaic, sgraffito, bentwood — and context: a date between 1893 and 1914, a city with a known school, a building type (town house, apartment block, store, café, station entrance) from the style's repertoire.

Finally, the three classic misidentifications. Art Deco buildings (1920s–30s) are the great confusion: Deco is symmetrical, geometric, sunbursted and machine-finished — if it looks like a radio set, it is Deco; if it looks like a plant, it is Nouveau. Arts and Crafts buildings share the honesty and the craft but shun both the whiplash and the machine-made casting; their ornament is vernacular and structural, not Parisian and sinuous.

And the 'Art Nouveau' of modern gift shops — laser-cut curves on a curtain wall — is revival, not the style: date is a fact, not a feeling. Carry the five signs onto any street in Brussels, Riga, Barcelona or Nancy and the city will start explaining itself.

A worked example: reading the Secession Building

Apply the method to the hardest case in this book — the Secession Building in Vienna, which looks, at first glance, almost classical. Sign one, the whiplash curve: nearly absent in the masonry, but present in the gilded laurel dome's woven leaves and in Moser's painted frieze — a single vote, weak. Sign two, structure as ornament: the building is a plain exhibition box and says so; its one flourish, the dome, is an iron structure worn as a crown — a vote, strong in kind. Sign three, the total interior: Olbrich designed the furniture, the door handles, even the attendants' world, and the flexible gallery was an instrument for total exhibitions — a vote. Sign four, asymmetry: the composition is in fact symmetrical — no vote, and the method tells you something real: Vienna was already disciplining the style. Sign five, stylised nature: laurel, owls, the three arts' masks — nature as emblem, flattened into symbol — a clear vote. Verdict: four of five, with the fifth consciously refused — Art Nouveau at its most Viennese, caught in the act of becoming modernism. The method's value is precisely that it registers the refusal as information, rather than failing the building for it.



Photo: C.Stadler/Bwag, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 4.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Wien_-_Secessionsgeb%C3%A4ude.JPG

Nouveau, Deco, Arts and Crafts: a three-way check

Field confusion usually involves three suspects, and a minute's comparison separates them. Against Art Deco (1920s–30s): Deco loves symmetry, the sunburst, the zigzag, the stepped profile and the machine finish; Nouveau loves asymmetry, the tendril, the swell and the hand finish. Deco's nature is heraldic — stylised into shields and chevrons; Nouveau's nature is botanical, still growing. Against the Arts and Crafts (1880s–1910s): the shared DNA is honesty and craft, but the Crafts distrust the city and the machine, build in vernacular materials, and ornament by construction and carving in a medieval spirit; Nouveau embraces the city, casts its ornament in foundries, and ornaments by line in a spirit of deliberate novelty. A useful pocket test for all three: ask what the building does with iron. Arts and Crafts hides it or hammers it like a blacksmith saint; Art Nouveau draws with it in public; Art Deco replaces it with chrome geometry. Date, city and building type then confirm what the iron has told you.

ARCHITECTURAL HISTORY SERIES · BOOK 1

16

Decline: Cost, Caricature and War, 1905–1918

The wilderness years, 1918–1950

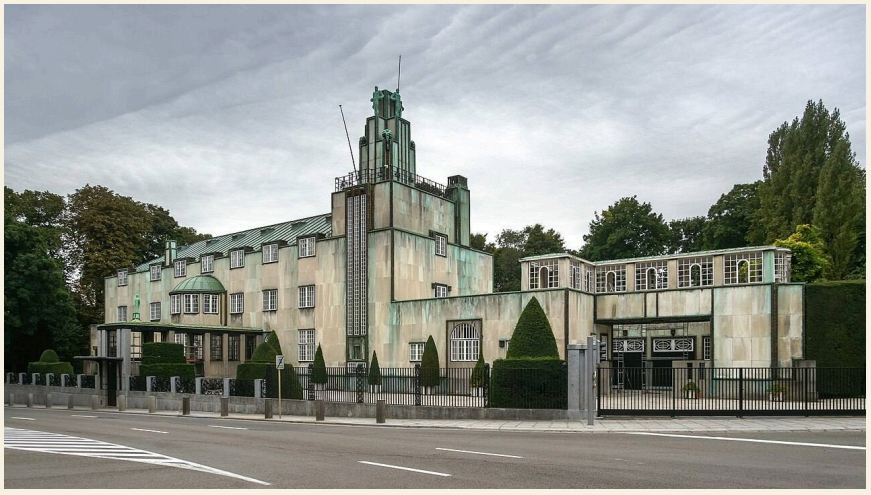


Photo: PtrQs, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 4.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:20120923_Brussels_PalaisStoclet_Hoffmann_DSC06725_PtrQs.jpg

Art Nouveau died young, and the autopsy lists several causes, all true. The first was economic. The style's effects depended on hand labour at the exact moment when hand labour's price was rising fastest: the mosaicist, the glass-painter, the carver, the smith. A Horta interior cost like jewellery because it was jewellery. Industrial patrons of 1895 had accepted the price as the cost of modernity; their sons, facing new taxes and new tastes, declined. Guimard's answer — the foundry catalogue, the repeatable casting — saved the entrances and standardised the charm away; the style's industrial wing survived precisely by ceasing to be total.

The second cause was satiety. Success flooded the market with imitation: 'nouveau' teapots, postcards, suburban villas with a tendril glued on. By 1902 the style was already a music-hall joke in Paris and a department-store category in London. Movements that begin as revolts against fashion are unusually defenceless against becoming fashion, and Art Nouveau had spread so fast, through print, that its half-life was spent in advance. The third cause was internal: the style contained its own critics. In Vienna and Glasgow its best architects were already straightening it into modernism; Loos gave the straightening a philosophy; Behrens gave it a factory. The whiplash did not so much fall as get outgrown by its own children.

The First World War administered the coup de grâce. The client class was ruined or taxed into modesty; the craftsmen were conscripted; Brussels, Nancy and Riga became battlefields or occupied cities; the international exhibition circuit that had been the style's circulatory system stopped for a generation. When building resumed, the world wanted hygiene, speed and housing in quantity — the white, flat-roofed modernism of the 1920s, against which the surviving Art Nouveau masters looked like survivors indeed. Horta, in wartime exile, designed the Palais des Beaux-Arts in Brussels (1919–28) in a stripped, geometric classicism that is already Deco's neighbour. Guimard's late Paris work is similarly calmed. The style's very completeness hastened the forgetting: it belonged so precisely to 1893–1914 that the post-war world filed it as a period room and closed the door.

What replaced it learned from it even while denouncing it. Art Deco took the total-design ambition, the luxury craft and the stylised nature, and machined them into symmetry. The Bauhaus took the unity of art and craft, the workshop school (Van de Velde's Weimar institution was its direct ancestor) and the doctrine of design for life. Modernism took the free plan, the honest material, the exposed structure. The curve went underground into streamlining, biomorphism and the organic architecture of Aalto and the late Wright — and waited, in provincial suburbs and unfashionable museums, for its resurrection.

The wilderness years, 1918–1950

Between the wars the style suffered the fate reserved for the recently fashionable: not hatred but embarrassment. Buildings were 'modernised' by the removal of their ornament — Brussels and Paris lost carved doorways, stained glass and whole interiors to the skip, often at the hands of owners who believed themselves improvers. Guimard's Castel Henriette and Horta's Maison du Peuple survived this period only to fall later (1969 and 1965 respectively), but the interwar decades quietly destroyed more Art Nouveau than the war did: shopfronts refaced, metro entrances melted down in quantity, Nancy furniture burned for firewood in the hard winters, as contemporaries bitterly recorded. The official histories of modern architecture compounded the erasure by writing the style in as a decorative dead end — a judgement the more effective because the men writing those histories, Pevsner's generation, were simultaneously preserving its memory in their footnotes.

Yet the wilderness was never total. Prague and Riga, behind new national borders, simply kept living in their stock. Barcelona's bourgeoisie kept the Eixample facades through taste's winter as through the Civil War's summer. In Paris, the Musée des Arts Décoratifs stored what the market discarded. And in 1939 Hector Guimard, exiled in New York, made a last attempt to donate his archive and a collection of his work to France — the offer was refused by the city he had ornamented, a small perfect emblem of the period's judgement, and of its cost.

ARCHITECTURAL HISTORY SERIES · BOOK 1

17
Revival and Conservation: The Second Life of the Style

Museums and the market today



Photo: Pudelek, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 4.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Otto_Wagner_Pavillon_-_Karlsplatz.jpg

The wheel turned slowly, then all at once. The first rescuers were scholars and photographers: Robert Schmutzler's Art Nouveau (1962) gave the movement its first serious history, the same decade in which Brussels watched the Maison du Peuple demolished (1965) in the face of an international petition — a martyrdom that taught the heritage movement its tactics. Surrealism had kept a candle burning (Dalí championed Gaudí and Guimard's 'terribly beautiful' edibles of architecture), and the 1960s pop generation, raised on Mucha posters reprinted for rock concerts, adopted the style as psychedelia's respectable ancestor. Museums followed the market; the market followed the posters; the buildings followed last, as buildings do.

Conservation then achieved, piece by piece, what enthusiasm could not. The Horta Museum opened in the architect's own house in 1969 and became the style's pilgrimage church. Paris listed and restored Guimard's surviving Métro entrances; two original canopied pavilions — Porte Dauphine and Abbesses — still serve passengers. Vienna restored the Secession after war damage and, in 1985–86, to its 1898 splendour. Barcelona, enriched and self-confident after the 1992 Olympics, restored the Palau de la Música's glass and the Casa Batlló's skin, and opened Gaudí's houses as museums of world rank. The legal capstone came from UNESCO: the Works of Antoni Gaudí (1984, extended 2005), the Palau de la Música and Hospital de Sant Pau (1997), Riga's historic centre (1997), Horta's four town houses (2000) and the Palais Stoclet (2009) — the style inscribed, in effect, as one of humanity's official treasures.

Revival has its own dangers, and a complete history should name them. The 'Art Nouveau look' is now a global décor product — printed curves, resin tendrils, themed cafés from Shanghai to São Paulo — which reproduces the style's surface while inverting its method, exactly the confusion Chapter 10 warned against. Conservation faces subtler questions: how to restore interiors designed as totalities when half the furniture is in museums on three continents; how the Glasgow School of Art, gutted by fire in 2018 mid-restoration, should be rebuilt — as replica, as ruin or as new work in the old spirit. These are live arguments among professionals, and this book takes no side beyond insisting on the evidence: the drawings, the photographs, the surviving fabric. What is not in doubt is the verdict of the last forty years. The style that 1920 dismissed as a decorative fever is now understood as the hinge on which the nineteenth century turned into the twentieth — and its buildings, once slated for demolition, anchor the identity and the tourist economy of half a dozen European cities.

Museums and the market today

The institutional landscape is now dense. The Horta Museum anchors Brussels, which markets itself — with the Art Nouveau Brussels network of open houses — as the style's capital; the Leopold Museum and the Secession hold Vienna's flame; the Musée d'Orsay's 1900 gallery and the Musée de l'École de Nancy curate France's two schools; Riga's Art Nouveau Centre, installed in an Eisenstein-era apartment on Alberta iela, preserves a complete bourgeois interior as a time capsule; Barcelona's Gaudí houses count their visitors in millions. The auction market tells the same story in numbers: furniture by Majorelle and Gallé, Tiffany lamps and Mackintosh pieces that changed hands for firewood prices in 1950 now anchor sales, and the poster market has made Mucha as reproducible a brand as any living artist.

Tourism completes the circuit and poses the current question. The style that was designed for the private interior now earns its keep as public spectacle — queues outside Casa Batlló, timed tickets at the Sagrada Família, Instagram beneath the Métro signs. Conservation doctrine has had to grow from saving buildings to managing their popularity, and the best current practice — visible at the Hôtel Solvay's careful opening and the Palau de la Música's managed light — treats the visitor flow itself as a conservation material. The movement that invented the exhibition interior has become one, permanently.

PLATES · II

Plate VII — Karlsplatz Station, Vienna



Photo: Pudelek, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 4.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Otto_Wagner_Pavillon_-_Karlsplatz.jpg

Wagner's twin pavilions of 1898–99: marble slabs hung on an iron frame, gilded sunflower ornament screwed on like jewellery. Demolition was planned in the 1960s; the city dismantled, stored and re-erected them instead — preservation as policy, learned the hard way.

PLATES · II

Plate VIII — The Horta Museum Stair, Brussels

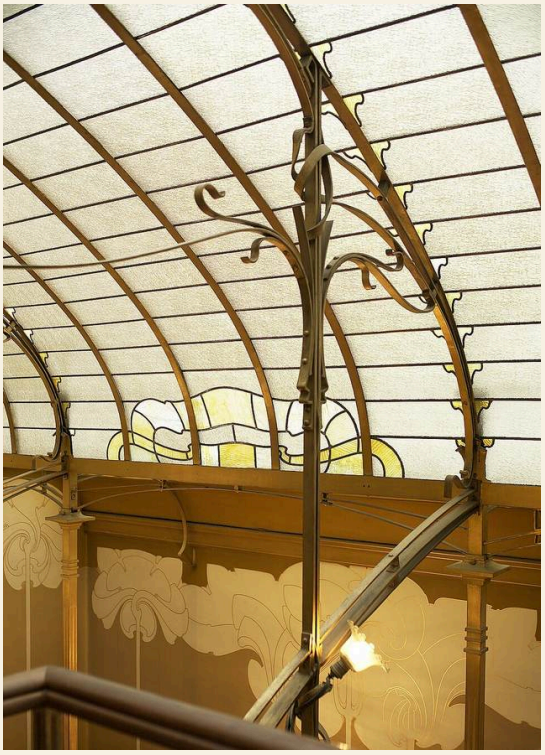


Photo: via Wikimedia Commons (CC0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Staircase_of_the_Victor_Horta_own_house_(25,_rue_Am%C3%A9ricaine,_1060,_Brussels).jpg

The architect's own house, designed as a visiting card: the stair rises through a glazed well past mosaic, marble and iron tendrils, in the most photographed interior of the Belgian new art.

PLATES · II

Plate IX — Palau de la Música Catalana, Barcelona

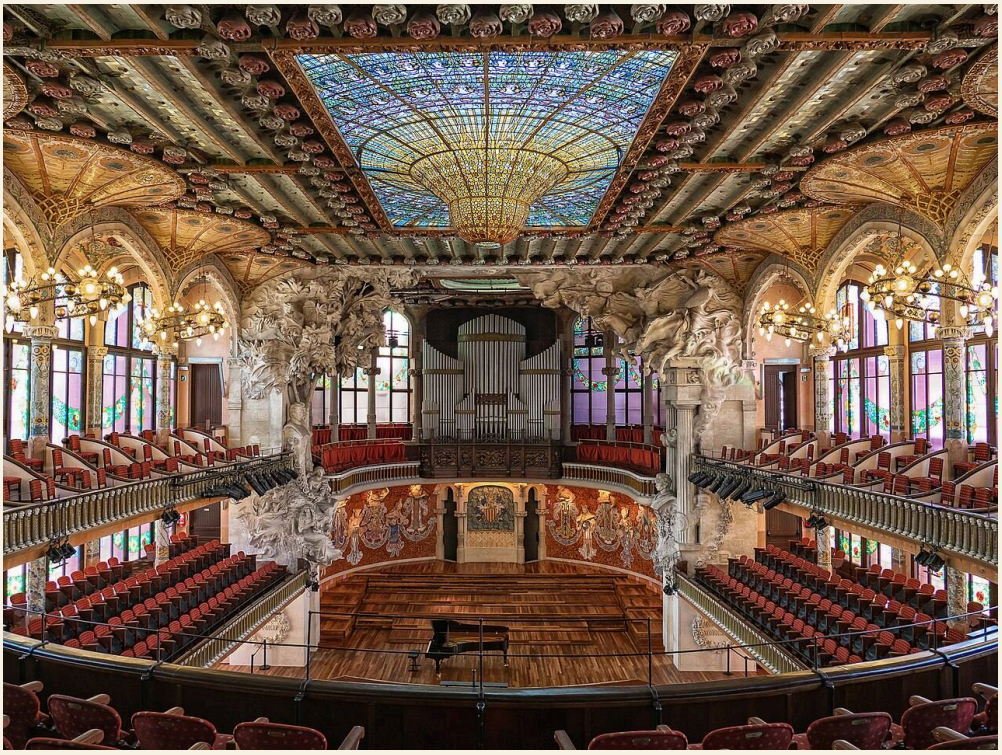


Photo: Tudoi61, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 4.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Palau_de_la_M%C3%BAsica_Catalana-Palace_of_Catalan_Music_(Image_2).jpg

Domènech's concert hall turns a steel frame into a greenhouse of music: a skylight like an inverted droplet, a stage framed by sculpture, and stained glass where other halls have walls.

PLATES · II

Plate X — Casa Milà (La Pedrera), Barcelona



Photo: Yair Haklai, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 4.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Antoni_Gaud%C3%AD-Casa_Mil%C3%A0-Barcelona.jpg

Gaudí's stone wave of 1906–12, self-supporting facade, free-plan flats and a roofscape of chimneys masked as warriors — the apartment house reimagined as geology.

PLATES · II

Plate XI — Palais Stoclet, Brussels



Photo: PtrQs, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 4.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:20120923_Brussels_PalaisStoclet_Hoffmann_DSC06725_PtrQs.jpg

Hoffmann's marble tower-house for a Brussels banker (1905–11): the Secession idea grown rich and serene, its dining room wrapped in Klimt's golden mosaics.

PLATES · II

Plate XII — The Hill House, Helensburgh



Photo: Anthony O'Neil, via geograph.org.uk (CC BY-SA 2.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:The_Hill_House,_Helensburgh_-_geograph.org.uk_-_1570975.jpg

Mackintosh and Margaret Macdonald's total interior in a Scottish suburb: white rooms, stencilled roses, and a main bedroom composed like a watercolour you sleep inside.

PLATES · II

Plate XIII — The Lavirotte Building, Paris



Photo: Binche, via Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 3.0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Immeuble_Lavirotte_-_Paris_-_France_-_Facade.jpg

29 Avenue Rapp (1901): Jules Lavirotte wraps a concrete-framed apartment house in stoneware by Alexandre Bigot, until the facade itself becomes a ceramic relief — pottery at the scale of a street.

PLATES · II

Plate XIV — Mucha's JOB Poster, 1896



Artwork: Alphonse Mucha, via Wikimedia Commons (public domain). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:JOB,_cigarette_paper_advertisement_by_Alfons_Mucha,_1898.jpg

The poster that taught Paris the style in a single winter: a woman, a cigarette, and hair arranged as pure line. The new art's most efficient ambassador was printed paper.

ARCHITECTURAL HISTORY SERIES · BOOK 1

18

Legacy: What Art Nouveau Teaches the Working Designer

The style in the present century

What to steal: a practitioner's checklist

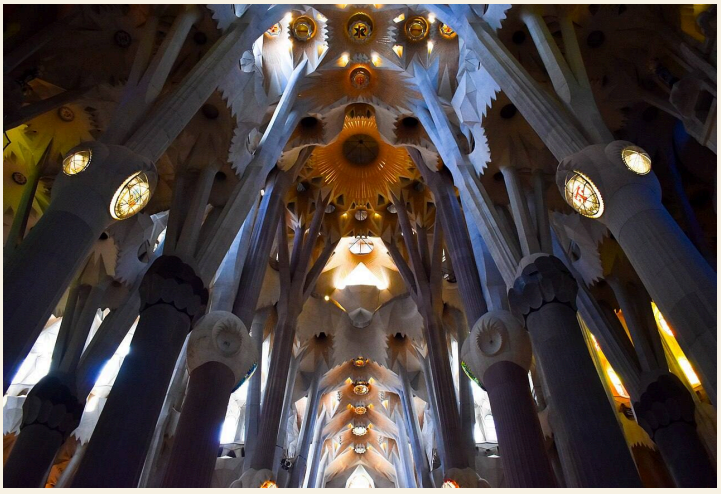


Photo: Julian Lupyan, via Wikimedia Commons (CC0). Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Nave_of_Sagrada_Fam%C3%ADlia,_Barcelona,_2023.jpg

A history book in a working journal should end with tools, not elegy. Art Nouveau leaves today's designer at least five usable lessons. First: the plan is the ornament. Horta's fame rests on a stairwell that solves light and circulation; Gaudí's, on a light-well that equalises daylight. Begin with the section and the daylight, and let the building's beauty be the visible form of those decisions. Second: structure can carry the decoration. The Tassel's columns, Wagner's bolts, Sullivan's grid — each generates its ornament from its construction, which is why none of it dates the way applied decoration dates. Third: design the sequence, not the object. The Brussels interior works because door, stair, room and handle are one thought; contemporary practice, split among consultants, recovers this unity only by deliberate effort — and clients can feel the difference instantly.

Fourth: materials have meanings, so specify like it matters. Wagner chose tile because it washes; Gaudí chose broken tile because it was cheap, local and luminous; Mackintosh chose dark timber because the library's light needed a foil. Every one of those choices is an argument a designer can still make in a meeting. Fifth — the cautionary lesson — novelty is perishable, so build the idea, not the gesture. The whiplash curve as a motif was exhausted in fifteen years; the whiplash as a method — form generated from growth, use and structure — is inexhaustible, and runs through Aalto's vases, the Sydney Opera House's shells and today's parametric facades, whose designers, whether they know it or not, are Horta's heirs with better software.

That is where this book ends: with the style restored to its proper size. Art Nouveau was not a decorative interlude between the real business of the nineteenth century and the real business of the twentieth. It was the moment architecture first tried, consciously and completely, to be modern — to make new materials, new plans, new cities and new lives into a single art. It failed, gloriously and briefly, and every serious designer since has been working with its tools. The remaining books of this series take up the other chapters of the long story — the Gothic engineers, the classical orders, the castle builders, the modernists themselves. The method will be the same: the complete history, the honest materials, the buildings in depth, and the signs that let you read them in the street.

The style in the present century

Walk the present century with the five signs in your pocket and the style keeps surfacing. The organic wing of contemporary architecture — the biomorphic shells, the parametric facades whose algorithms grow ornament from structural stress exactly as Horta grew it from his drawn line — is its most respectable descendant, though few of its practitioners cite the ancestry. Popular culture kept the other line: Mucha's women sell everything from tea to tattoos; Prague, Riga and Brussels sell themselves to visitors in whiplash lettering; film and television reach for the style whenever a story needs belle-époque Paris or fin-de-siècle Vienna, until the Métro entrance functions on screen as the Eiffel Tower's understudy. Even the style's name for its own city district — Brussels' 'Art Nouveau capital' branding — would have pleased Bing, who understood before anyone that a movement is also a marque.

The working designer's inheritance, finally, is a discipline of attention. Art Nouveau's buildings reward the visitor who looks slowly — at the joint, the handle, the grade of tile in a light-well — and punish the one who photographs only the silhouette. They were made by people who believed a door handle could carry a civilisation's idea of itself. However the history is periodised, that belief is the style's bequest, and it is available to any designer, in any idiom, who is willing to draw the small things as carefully as the large.

What to steal: a practitioner's checklist

For the working architect, distilled from the eighteen chapters above: One — design the threshold sequence first; the Tassel plan is a lesson in how much of a building's character is decided between the street door and the stair. Two — give the stair and the hall the light budget; Horta spent his clients' money on a glazed well, and it is what every visitor remembers. Three — draw the ironwork, the handles and the lettering yourself, or accept that the building's most-touched surfaces will speak someone else's language. Four — let one material lead each room and let structure show; Wagner's bolted marble is honest in a way applied historicism never was. Five — price totality before promising it: the style died of its own completeness, and the Werkstätte's ledgers are the cautionary tale pinned inside the manifesto. Six — when the fashion turns, as it will, build the parts worth keeping: the plan, the light and the section outlive the ornament, exactly as the style's survivors prove.

Timeline: The Style in Dates

1883	Arthur Heygate Mackmurdo designs the title page of Wren's City Churches in London — often cited as the first fully Art Nouveau graphic, all stems and flame-like curves. Antoni Gaudí, newly qualified, begins work in Barcelona; his Casa Vicens (1883–85) mixes Moorish, Gothic and pure invention.
1893	In Brussels, Paul Hankar builds his own house on the rue Defacqz and Victor Horta begins the Hôtel Tassel for the scientist Émile Tassel. The Tassel stair — iron columns flowering into tendrils over a mosaic floor — is the first complete Art Nouveau interior. Architecture has a new style.
1895	The Paris dealer Siegfried Bing opens his gallery Maison de l'Art Nouveau, giving the movement its French — and eventually its international — name. Horta starts the Hôtel Solvay; Hector Guimard begins the Castel Béranger in Paris.
1896	Georg Hirth founds the Munich journal Jugend, source of the German name Jugendstil. Otto Wagner publishes Modern Architecture in Vienna, demanding that design answer modern life. Horta begins the Maison du Peuple, a people's house with an iron-and-glass facade, for the Belgian Workers' Party.
1897	In Vienna, Gustav Klimt, Joseph Maria Olbrich, Josef Hoffmann, Koloman Moser and others secede from the conservative Künstlerhaus and found the Vienna Secession. In Glasgow, Charles Rennie Mackintosh wins the competition for the Glasgow School of Art; its first phase rises 1897–99.
1898	Olbrich's Secession Building opens in Vienna under Hevesi's motto: 'To every age its art, to art its freedom.' Wagner's Majolica House covers a Vienna apartment block in floral tiles. Guimard's Castel Béranger wins the City of Paris facade competition. In Darmstadt, Grand Duke Ernst Ludwig plans an artists' colony.
1900	The Paris Exposition Universelle makes Art Nouveau world-famous — and gives Paris Guimard's cast-iron Métro entrances, the style's most democratic monuments. Park Güell begins in Barcelona; Bing's pavilion at the fair exports the style to America and Japan.
1901	The Darmstadt artists' colony exhibition 'A Document of German Art' shows complete furnished houses, including Peter Behrens' own. The Lavirotte Building raises a ceramic jungle on Paris's avenue Rapp. The École de Nancy formalises the French provincial school around Émile Gallé and Louis Majorelle.
1902	The Turin exhibition of modern decorative art is the style's Italian showcase. Klimt paints the Beethoven Frieze for the Secession's Beethoven exhibition. Mackintosh begins the Hill House for the publisher Walter Blackie.
1904	Gaudí starts the remodelling of Casa Batlló on Barcelona's Passeig de Gràcia. Wagner begins the Kirche am Steinhof and the Austrian Postal Savings Bank in Vienna. Glasgow School of Art's west wing — with its great library — is designed (built 1907–09).
1905	Domènech i Montaner begins the Palau de la Música Catalana in Barcelona, a greenhouse of music built in three years. In Brussels, work starts on Josef Hoffmann's Palais Stoclet — where the curve already straightens into the next age.
1906	Casa Batlló is completed; Gaudí moves on to Casa Milà, the 'stone quarry' whose self-supporting facade needs no load-bearing walls. Casa Lleó Morera is finished on the same Barcelona block.
1908	Adolf Loos writes 'Ornament and Crime' in Vienna (published in French in 1913), declaring ornament a waste of labour — the intellectual death sentence of the style his own city had raised. The Kirche am Steinhof has opened the year before.
1910	The Brussels International Exhibition shows the style tipping toward the straighter lines of what will become Art Deco. Gaudí's Casa Milà nears completion (1912). Horta is designing in a classicising manner.
1914	The First World War ends the movement's world: clients, craftsmen and capitals are gone, and the Werkbund exhibition in Cologne already displays the functional future. Art Nouveau survives as a period style — complete, dated and, within

fifty years, treasured.

Gazetteer: Where to See the Style

Brussels, Belgium	The capital of the style. Start at the Horta Museum (the architect's own house and studio), then the Hôtel Solvay (booked visits), the Horta-designed Waucquez store (now the Belgian Comic Strip Center) and the Old England store (now the Musical Instruments Museum, whose rooftop café surveys the city Horta rebuilt). The Art Nouveau walking routes of the Ixelles and Saint-Gilles communes pass dozens of facades; the Maison Autrique opens Horta's first manner to visitors.
Paris, France	Enter by Guimard: the surviving Métro canopies at Porte Dauphine and Abbesses, then the Castel Béranger (Rue La Fontaine, exterior), Castel Henriette's surviving contemporaries in the 16th arrondissement, and the Lavirotte building at 29 Avenue Rapp. The Musée d'Orsay holds the furniture and the Grafton-era objects; the department stores — La Samaritaine's 1905 Frantz Jourdain steel-and-glass interior heritage and Printemps' dome — complete the circuit.
Nancy, France	The provincial school at full strength: the Musée de l'École de Nancy (in Majorelle's own milieu), the Villa Majorelle (visitable), Gallé's glass in the museum's lower rooms, and whole streets of Nancy-school houses around the Parc de Saurupt. Nancy rewards the walker who looks at doorways: the school's naturalism lives at hand height.
Barcelona, Spain	The Eixample's Illa de la Discòrdia sets Batlló, Amatller and Lleó Morera in one argumentative row. Add the Palau de la Música Catalana (concerts and tours), the Hospital de Sant Pau (now a museum campus), Park Güell, Casa Milà, and the Sagrada Família — still rising. Book everything ahead; the city's Modernista stock is its identity and its queue.
Vienna, Austria	The Secession building (with Klimt's Beethoven Frieze below), the Majolica and Musen houses on the Linke Wienzeile, the Karlsplatz pavilions, the Ankerhaus and the Postal Savings Bank hall, then Steinhof church on the city's green edge — best reached as Wagner planned it, by his own Stadtbahn lines. The Leopold Museum carries the story into the Werkstätte years.
Glasgow, United Kingdom	The Mackintosh city: the Glasgow School of Art (fire-damaged; viewing per current conservation status), the Willow Tea Rooms on Sauchiehall Street (restored to the 1903 scheme), The Lighthouse (Mackintosh's first public building, a design centre), the House for an Art Lover (built 1989–96 from his 1901 competition drawings), and the Hill House at Helensburgh, half an hour away.
Riga, Latvia	The densest surviving stock in northern Europe: Alberta iela and the Quiet Centre's facades by Eisenstein and his contemporaries, the Riga Art Nouveau Centre's preserved apartment interior, and the museum's stairwell-by-stairwell documentation. Come in summer, look up, and walk slowly — a third of the centre is the style.
Prague, Czech Republic	The Municipal House (Obecní dům) is the essential interior — Mucha's mayoral hall inside a concert-and-café palace — with the Mucha Museum, the Wilson Station hall, and the Vinohrady and New Town apartment streets around it. Prague's Sezession is Central Europe's hinge between Vienna and the Slavic revival.
Budapest, Hungary	Ödön Lechner's city: the Museum of Applied Arts (with its Zsolnay-tiled roof), the Postal Savings Bank with its rooftop walk of folk-motif ornament, the Geological Institute, and Zsolnay-ceramic facades across Pest. Book the museum's roof tour when offered; the green-gold tiles are the national style made visible.
Turin, Italy	Italy kept the appointment: the Casa Fenoglio-Lafleur and the streets of the Crocetta and San Salvario quarters hold Liberty Turin, with D'Aronco's 1902 exhibition legacy in the city's museums. Turin pairs naturally with Milan, where the Casa Galimberti's painted tiles announce the Stile Liberty's commercial charm.
Darmstadt, Germany	The Mathildenhöhe artists' colony: Olbrich's Wedding Tower and exhibition halls, the Ernst Ludwig House, and the artists' villas — including Behrens' own house — preserved as the 1901 exhibition's permanent exhibit, now UNESCO-listed. The colony is the style's argument for the planned artistic community, kept intact.
Helsinki, Finland	National Romantic stone: the Pohjola Building's folklore-carved facade, the National Museum and central station (Saarinen's granite gravity, completed 1919), and the Katajanokka district's granite apartment houses. Helsinki shows

what the new art became when it froze into national bedrock — and survived.

Key Figures

Victor Horta (1861–1947, Belgian)	The architect who lit the fuse. Trained in Ghent and Brussels, assistant to Alphonse Balat, he built the Hôtel Tassel (1893–94) while still a young professor and followed it with the Autrique and Solvay houses, the Maison du Peuple and the Waucquez store. Losing his wife and then his country to war and fashion, he ended in a neoclassical register — which has never obscured the verdict: the Tassel stair remains the single most consequential interior of the 1890s.
Paul Hankar (1859–1901, Belgian)	Brussels' second founder, too often read as Horta's echo. His own house (1893) and the Ciamberlani house announced the sgraffito-clad, Japan-touched Brussels variant; he pioneered the artist's house as manifesto and died at forty-one, his reputation still catching up with his priority.
Hector Guimard (1867–1942, French)	Paris's public face. The Castel Béranger made him famous at thirty-one; the Métro entrances made him immortal. A total designer — furniture line, foundry, typography, wallpaper — exiled by war and fashion, he died in New York; his widow's gift of drawings to the Musée d'Orsay began his resurrection.
Antoni Gaudí (1852–1926, Catalan)	The style's greatest structural imagination. From the Palau Güell to the Sagrada Família, his catenary models, ruled surfaces and trencadís made structure and ornament one system; run down by a tram in 1926, he was buried in his unfinished church, which is being completed around his tomb a century later. Seven of his works are UNESCO-listed.
Lluís Domènech i Montaner (1850–1923, Catalan)	Modernisme's statesman — professor, publisher, politician — and builder of its two civic summits, the Palau de la Música Catalana and the Hospital de Sant Pau. Where Gaudí mythologised structure, Domènech organised it: forty-four pavilions of one hospital share one decorative grammar.
Otto Wagner (1841–1918, Austrian)	Vienna's bridge from empire to modernism. Professor, city planner and author of Moderne Architektur (1896), his Majolica House, Postal Savings Bank and Kirche am Steinhof taught a generation — Loos, Hoffmann, Olbrich among them — that a modern building must be honestly built before it may be beautifully dressed.
Joseph Maria Olbrich (1867–1908, Austrian-German)	The Secession's architect and Darmstadt's. His exhibition building gave Vienna its golden cabbage-domed icon; his Wedding Tower gave Darmstadt its crown. Dead of leukaemia at forty, he is the style's most poignant 'what if'.
Charles Rennie Mackintosh (1868–1928, Scottish)	Glasgow's reformer, designer of the School of Art, the tea rooms and the Hill House, working in lifelong partnership with Margaret Macdonald. Adored in Vienna, neglected at home, he died in London in 1928 painting watercolours — and was resurrected after 1960 as Scotland's national designer.
Margaret Macdonald Mackintosh (1864–1933, Scottish)	Co-author of the Glasgow Style: with her sister Frances and the Mackintosh brothers she formed the Four; her gesso panels and elongated figures supplied the Glasgow interiors' soul, and Charles himself wrote that while he had talent, Margaret had genius. This book follows the record in treating the Glasgow work as a partnership.
Alphonse Mucha (1860–1939, Czech)	The poster made flesh: his Gismonda (1894) invented le style Mucha overnight, and his Slav Epic later traded Parisian fame for national duty. Arrested by the Gestapo in 1939, he died weeks after release — the style's most beloved image-maker and its last casualty.
Henry van de Velde (1863–1957, Belgian)	Painter turned total designer: his Bloemenwerf house, his interiors for Bing, and his Weimar school — the direct ancestor of the Bauhaus — make him the human bridge between Art Nouveau and the modern movement that disowned it.
Louis Comfort Tiffany (1848–1933, American)	Glass as light: his Favrile glass, his windows and his lamps — many designed, as this book records, by Clara Driscoll and her department — gave the American new art its colour and its commerce. His studio's pavilion at Paris 1900 closed the transatlantic circuit Bing had opened.

Glossary

Art Nouveau	The French and international name of the style, from Siegfried Bing's Paris gallery Maison de l'Art Nouveau (opened 1895).
Catenary arch	An arch shaped like a hanging chain's curve inverted; Gaudí derived vault forms from hanging-chain models, so the structure stands in pure compression.
Édicule	Guimard's smaller Métro entrance type: two 'Metropolitain' sign posts with an amber glass canopy — a kiosk in the form of a plant.
Gesamtkunstwerk	German: 'total work of art'. A building and everything in it designed as one indivisible conception.
Jugendstil	The German name of the style, from the Munich journal Jugend ('Youth'), founded 1896.
Majolica (maiolica)	Tin-glazed earthenware with painted decoration; as architectural tiles, the washable skin of Wagner's Majolica House.
Modernisme	The Catalan name of the style, bound up with the Catalan cultural revival (Renaixença).
Mosaic	Images or patterns formed of small pieces (tesserae) of stone, glass or ceramic set in mortar — floors in Brussels, muses in Barcelona.
Oriel	A bay window projecting from an upper floor and carried on brackets or corbels; a Horta speciality for pulling light into narrow houses.
Parabolic arch	An arch following a parabola; Gaudí's structural signature in entrances and galleries from the Palau Güell onward.
Sgraffito	Decoration scratched through a surface layer of plaster to a contrasting layer beneath; revived on Brussels and Prague facades.
Secession	The 1897 breakaway of Viennese artists from the official Künstlerhaus; by extension, the Austrian name of the style.
Stile Liberty	The Italian name of the style, after Liberty & Co. of London, retailer of the new design.
Trencadís	Catalan mosaic of broken ceramic shards, developed by Gaudí and Jujol; cheap, waterproof and shimmering.
Ver Sacrum	'Sacred Spring' — the Vienna Secession's journal (1898–1903) and its motto of artistic renewal.
Whiplash curve	The style's signature line: an asymmetrical, swelling-and-tapering curve likened to a cracking whip or a growing stem.
Wiener Werkstätte	'Vienna Workshops' (1903–32), the design company of Hoffmann and Moser that carried Secession design into objects and interiors.
Bentwood	Wood softened with steam and bent into continuous curves; Thonet's Vienna factories industrialised the technique that furnished the movement's cafés.
Cameo glass	Glass of two or more fused layers, etched or carved so the design stands in one colour against another; Gallé's signature technique at Nancy.
Eixample	The 'Extension' of Barcelona, Ildefons Cerdà's chamfered grid (from 1859), the chessboard on which Modernisme was played.
Faience	Glazed ceramic ware; as facade tiles and fireplaces it gave the style washable, fired colour.
Favrile glass	Louis Comfort Tiffany's trademark iridescent art glass, patented 1894, the material of the famous lampshades.
Les XX	'The Twenty': the Brussels exhibiting society (1883–93) whose salons made the Belgian capital the exchange floor of the European avant-garde.

Lithography	Printing from a prepared stone or plate; the colour lithograph was the poster art — and the publicity engine — of the style.
Mansana de la Discòrdia	The 'Block of Discord' on Barcelona's Passeig de Gràcia, where houses by Gaudí, Domènech and Puig i Cadafalch compete side by side.
Pâte de verre	A paste of ground glass cast in a mould and fired; used by Daum and others for sculptural vessels in the Nancy school.
Renaixença	The nineteenth-century revival of Catalan language and culture, the political soil in which Modernisme grew.
Ringstrasse	Vienna's circular boulevard of revivalist state buildings (from 1858), the official architecture against which the Secession revolted.
Sitzmaschine	'Machine for sitting': Josef Hoffmann's adjustable armchair of c. 1905, the Secession's furniture reduced to elegant engineering.

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